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Bio-inspired co-design: Integrating robotic maintenance considerations into turbine architecture

Chandan Sheikder [a,b,*], Weimin Zhang [a,b,**], Xiaopeng Chen [a,b], Fangxing Li [a,b], Zhengqing Zuo [b], Yichang Liu [a,b], Xiaohai He [a], Xinyan Tan [a], Shicheng Fan [a]

[a] School of Mechatronics Engineering, Beijing Institute of Technology, Beijing, 100081, China
[b] Zhengzhou Research Institute, Beijing Institute of Technology, Zhengzhou, 450000, China

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ABSTRACT

The sustainable growth of wind energy is critically challenged by the high cost and danger of inspecting and maintaining infrastructure, particularly in remote offshore locations. This review contends that bio-inspired and soft robotics present a transformative pathway toward autonomous and resilient wind farm operations. Our synthesis is built upon a systematic analysis of the convergence of biology and robotics, a focused evaluation of advancements in agile mobility and robust autonomy for harsh environments, and a critical appraisal of robotic inspection and repair. We demonstrate how principles from nature, such as animal locomotion, perception, and collective intelligence, are being harnessed to create robots that can navigate complex turbine structures, perform detailed inspections, and execute in situ repairs. The review culminates in a technology readiness roadmap, asserting that these interdisciplinary approaches are essential for significantly reducing the Levelized Cost of Energy (LCOE) and securing the future of wind power.

1. Introduction

The global transition to renewable energy is a critical pillar in mitigating the most severe impacts of climate change, as underscored by international agreements like the Paris Accord. Within this transition, wind energy has emerged as a mature and scalable technology poised for exponential growth. The International Energy Agency (IEA) has highlighted wind power as a cornerstone of a net-zero emissions by 2050 scenario, requiring a dramatic acceleration in annual capacity additions [1]. This expansion is particularly focused offshore, where stronger, more consistent winds offer the potential for significantly higher energy yields and reduced visual impact.

Recent analyses highlight that offshore wind is set to become a cornerstone of the future energy mix in Europe, Asia, and North America, with global capacity forecasts being consistently revised upwards [2]. Ambitious national targets, such as the European Union's goal of 300 GW of offshore wind capacity by 2050 and China's rapid deployment, signal a new era for the industry. However, the very environments that make offshore wind so promising also present profound engineering and economic challenges that threaten to constrain its sustainable growth. The levelized cost of energy (LCOE) for wind power has decreased substantially over the past decade, yet operations and maintenance (O&M) remain a significant economic bottleneck.

For onshore wind, O&M can account for 20-25% of the LCOE, but for offshore installations, this figure escalates dramatically to 25-35%, driven by the harsh marine environment and complex logistics [3]. These costs are primarily attributed to unplanned corrective maintenance and the logistical difficulties of performing routine inspections and repairs. Accessing offshore turbines requires specialized vessels, favorable weather windows, and highly trained personnel, leading to substantial downtime where turbines generate zero revenue. A single day of downtime for a modern offshore turbine can represent a five-figure loss in energy production [4].

Furthermore, as turbine sizes increase and farms move further from shore, these logistical challenges and associated costs are amplified, creating an urgent need for a paradigm shift in O&M strategies. Conventional O&M methodologies are not only costly but also fraught with risk. Manual inspection and repair of wind turbines involve technicians working at great heights, in confined spaces, and often in unpredictable, severe weather conditions. These activities carry an inherent risk of

* Corresponding author. School of Mechatronics Engineering, Beijing Institute of Technology, Beijing, 100081, China.
** Corresponding author. Zhengzhou Research Institute, Beijing Institute of Technology, Zhengzhou, 450000, China.
E-mail address: zhwm@bit.edu.cn (W. Zhang).

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catastrophic accidents. Data from the G + Global Offshore Wind Health and Safety Organisation consistently shows that transfer between vessels and turbines is a high-risk activity, and the industry continues to seek safer solutions [5].

Beyond the immediate human cost, these operations have an environmental footprint, relying on large, fuel-intensive service vessels. Moreover, the turbulent wind environment around a turbine and the complex steel structure of the tower create GPS-denied and perceptually degraded environments, where conventional robotic and navigation systems often fail. This combination of human safety concerns and operational complexity underscores the necessity for robotic systems that can operate autonomously and resiliently in these challenging settings. In confronting these challenges, a transformative opportunity lies at the intersection of robotics and biology.

This review focuses on two complementary fields: bio-inspired robotics (or biomimetics), which involves abstracting and applying design principles from nature to solve complex engineering problems, and soft robotics, which utilizes compliant, continuously deformable materials to create machines with embodied intelligence that can safely adapt to their environment. Nature provides a vast repository of proven solutions for mobility, sensing, and resilience. For instance, birds and insects exhibit unparalleled mastery of flight in gusty conditions, geckos can adhere to smooth surfaces without adhesives, and ant colonies efficiently explore and exploit complex terrains through swarm intelligence.

Thesis Statement: This review argues that the integration of bio-inspired design principles and soft robotic technologies is a key enabler for achieving fully autonomous, cost-effective, and resilient wind energy systems. For instance, recent advancements in morphing-wing drones demonstrate superior stability in turbulent wind conditions, directly addressing the challenge of aerial inspection in gusty environments [6]. By leveraging solutions refined by millions of years of evolution, we can develop robotic agents capable of navigating the chaotic wind farm environment, performing contact-based inspections with unprecedented delicacy, executing in situ repairs, and ultimately contributing to the design of next-generation, inherently resilient turbine structures. The compliant nature of soft robots mitigates the risk of damaging delicate composite blade surfaces during contact, while bio-inspired algorithms offer robust solutions for navigation and coordination where traditional GPS and pre-programmed paths are inadequate [6,7].

This paper provides a comprehensive synthesis of the state-of-the-art in bio-inspired and soft robotics for wind energy applications, with a forward-looking perspective on achieving full autonomy. Following this introduction, Section 2 details the systematic methodology employed for the literature review. Section 3 critically examines biomimetic and soft robotic platforms for access and mobility, covering aerial, climbing, and underwater systems. Section 4 delves into the core challenges of perception and autonomy in GPS-denied environments, reviewing bio-inspired sensor fusion and swarm intelligence algorithms. Section 5 explores the application of these robots for contact-based non-destructive testing (NDT) and in situ repair. Section 6 broadens the scope to discuss how bio-inspiration is directly influencing next-generation turbine design for enhanced performance and self-healing. Finally, Section 7 synthesizes the findings, presents a critical analysis of remaining challenges, and proposes a technology roadmap to guide future interdisciplinary research, concluding with a summary of the field's transformative potential.

2. Methodology of the literature review

This approach was designed not only to aggregate existing knowledge but also to identify emerging trends, technological gaps, and the trajectory of interdisciplinary convergence while ensuring maximum transparency and reproducibility.

The methodology was executed in five iterative phases: (1) Scoping and Question Formulation, (2) Strategic Literature Retrieval, (3) Rigorous Screening and Selection, (4) Thematic Data Extraction and Synthesis, and (5) Critical Appraisal and Trend Mapping. This structured process minimized selection bias and provided a robust foundation for the subsequent analysis and roadmap development. The initial phase involved defining the scope and articulating the central research questions (RQs) that would guide the entire inquiry. These questions were crafted to probe both the current state-of-the-art and the forward-looking potential of the field:

a) RQ1: How are bio-inspired locomotion paradigms (aerial, climbing, and aquatic) being engineered to overcome the specific mobility challenges posed by offshore and onshore wind turbine infrastructure?
b) RQ2: What advancements in bio-inspired perception, sensor fusion, and swarm intelligence are enabling resilient autonomy in the GPS-denied, perceptually degraded, and dynamically turbulent environments of wind farms?
c) RQ3: What are the comparative advantages and limitations of soft robotic systems versus traditional rigid robots for performing delicate contact-based inspections and complex in situ repairs on composite turbine blades?
d) RQ4: How can bio-inspired principles enable the co-design of wind turbines and their robotic maintenance systems to optimize the functional integration between infrastructure and autonomous agents, specifically addressing how turbine structural features can facilitate robotic access, adhesion, and repair operations?

RQ4 specifically addresses the co-design challenge where turbine architecture and robotic capabilities are optimized together rather than separately. This integrated approach contrasts with conventional practice, where turbines are designed independently and robots must adapt to existing structures. For example, incorporating standardized docking ports on turbine towers for climbing robots or designing blade surfaces with texture patterns that enhance adhesion for gecko-inspired crawlers while maintaining aerodynamic performance. This co-design paradigm recognizes that achieving truly autonomous maintenance requires turbines specifically architected to accommodate robotic access and intervention, creating synergistic optimization unavailable when these systems are developed in isolation.

With these RQs established, a strategic and expansive literature retrieval process was initiated. Searches were conducted across major scholarly databases, including Scopus, Web of Science, IEEE Xplore, and ASME Digital Collection, to capture peer-reviewed journal articles and conference proceedings. Given the field's rapid pace, the primary search horizon was limited to the last five years (2020-2024) to ensure the review's timeliness and focus on cutting-edge developments. However, to ensure the inclusion of foundational and seminal works, a systematic ‘snowballing’ technique was employed, scanning reference lists of key review articles to identify pivotal studies predating the five-year window. The search strategy utilized a complex Boolean logic structure that intertwined keywords from the three core domains. A representative query was ((“bio-inspired” OR biomimetic OR “soft robot*” OR “morphing wing” OR “swarm intelligence” OR “compliant mechanism”) AND (“wind turbine” OR “wind farm” OR “offshore wind”) AND (inspection OR maintenance OR repair OR “non-destructive testing” OR “structural health monitoring” OR autonomy OR navigation)).

This base string was meticulously adapted for the syntax of each database. To complement this, a systematic “snowballing” technique was employed; the reference lists of key review articles and seminal papers were exhaustively scanned to identify foundational studies predating the five-year window or those missed by database algorithms. Concurrently, a forward snowballing approach using Google Scholar's “Cited by” feature was instrumental in tracking the most recent research that has built upon these pivotal works, capturing cutting-edge developments from 2023 to 2024 [8,9].

The retrieval process yielded a substantial corpus of records, which were then subjected to a rigorous two-stage screening protocol based on predefined inclusion and exclusion criteria. The inclusion criteria mandated that studies must (i) be published in English in peer-reviewed venues; (ii) present primary research or a comprehensive review directly relevant to the RQs; (iii) feature a bio-inspired or soft robotic element as a core contribution, not merely an ancillary mention; and (iv) demonstrate clear applicability to wind energy operations, maintenance, or design. Studies were excluded if they focused solely on conventional robotics, general wind energy aerodynamics without a bio-inspired angle, or were purely speculative without technical validation.

The screening process employed dual independent reviewers to minimize selection bias, with any discrepancies resolved through discussion and consensus. This rigorous approach ensured comprehensive and unbiased literature selection, with any discrepancies resolved through discussion. The process followed a PRISMA flow, as illustrated in Fig. 1: initial identification of over 1300 records, removal of duplicates, title/abstract screening to exclude clearly irrelevant works, and finally, a detailed full-text assessment of the remaining articles against the strict eligibility criteria. This rigorous selection process resulted in a final corpus of 128 high-relevance studies for in-depth analysis [10,11]. While this number may appear limited given the interdisciplinary breadth of the field, the focused search strategy combined with systematic snowballing ensured comprehensive coverage of the most directly relevant and recent advances. The corpus size reflects our emphasis on high-relevance studies that explicitly bridge bio-inspired robotics with wind energy applications, rather than including foundational works from each discipline in isolation. A PRISMA flow diagram (Fig. 1) visually summarizes the entire selection process, enhancing transparency and reproducibility.

For the included studies, a structured data extraction process was implemented using a standardized template. This facilitated a systematic capture of key information, including bibliographic data; study type (e.g., experimental, simulation, conceptual); the specific biological model or soft robotic principle employed (e.g., bird flight, insect adhesion, octopus arm manipulation); the targeted wind energy application and task; key performance metrics (e.g., adhesion strength, flight endurance in turbulence, inspection accuracy); and an estimated Technology Readiness Level (TRL) based on the study's description. The synthesis was primarily narrative and thematic, moving beyond a mere summary to a critical integration of findings.

Studies were clustered into emergent thematic categories such as "Morphing-Wing UAVs for Gust Rejection," "Adhesion Mechanisms for Vertical Surfacing," and "Bio-inspired Algorithms for Swarm Inspection," allowing for cross-comparison of approaches, identification of convergent success factors, and pinpointing of persistent challenges [6,12,13]. This thematic organization directly mirrors the structure of the review's subsequent sections. Finally, a critical appraisal of the collected literature was conducted to assess the validity, impact, and maturity of the reported research. This involved evaluating the methodological rigor of experimental setups, the representativeness of simulation environments, the appropriateness of performance metrics, and the acknowledgment of limitations by the original authors.

This appraisal was crucial for weighting the evidence presented and for distinguishing between proven capabilities and promising but early-stage concepts. It directly informed the critical analysis of challenges and the formulation of the future research roadmap presented in the latter part of this review. By employing this multi-faceted methodology encompassing systematic search, rigorous filtering, thematic synthesis, and critical appraisal, this review achieves a comprehensive, current, and critically engaged perspective on a field that is pivotal to the sustainable and economical future of wind energy [2,14,15]. While designed to be comprehensive, this methodology acknowledges certain inherent limitations.

The restriction to English-language publications may introduce a language bias, potentially omitting significant contributions in other languages. The field's interdisciplinary nature means that relevant advances might be published in niche journals or presented at specialized conferences outside the core robotics or energy domains and could have been missed. The reliance on reported data means that the TRL assessments are estimations, and the true maturity of technologies within proprietary industrial R&D pipelines may be higher or lower than publicly documented. Finally, the qualitative nature of the synthesis, while critical and thematic, is inherently interpretative. Despite these limitations, the transparent and systematic process employed ensures that the review provides a representative, credible, and timely snapshot of the state-of-the-art, forming a solid foundation for the insights and projections that follow.

3. Biomimetic and soft robotic systems for wind turbine access and mobility

The operational challenges of wind turbine inspection and maintenance, particularly in offshore and complex environments, have

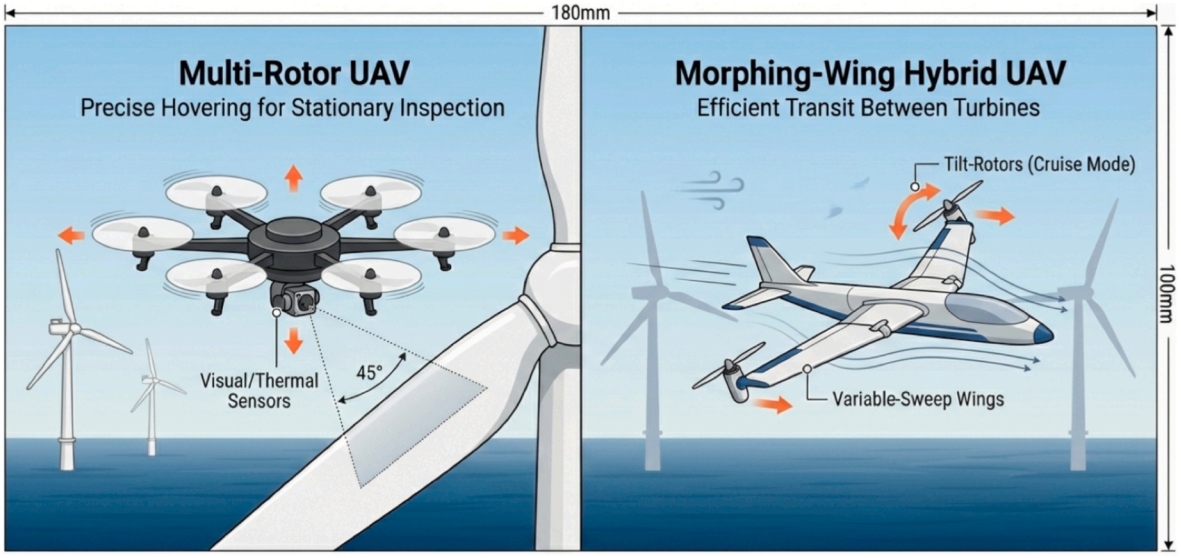


Fig. 1. *Operational comparison. Left: Conventional multi-rotor UAVs excel at precise, stationary hovering for detailed inspection. Right: Bio-inspired hybrid UAVs utilize morphing wings for gust rejection and* ***tilt-rotors (VTOL)*** *to switch between hovering for inspection and energy-efficient forward flight for transit between turbines.*

catalyzed the development of advanced robotic systems capable of accessing difficult-to-reach areas. Conventional robotic platforms, such as standard multi-rotor UAVs and rigid industrial arms, often struggle with the turbulent wind conditions, complex geometries, and delicate surfaces characteristic of wind turbine infrastructure [16,17,18]. Their limitations in adaptability, gust rejection, and safe physical interaction form the benchmark against which the potential advantages of bio-inspired and soft robotic approaches are evaluated in this review. In response, researchers have increasingly turned to biological systems for inspiration, developing biomimetic and soft robotic platforms that exhibit enhanced mobility, stability, and adaptability. This section critically reviews the state-of-the-art in aerial, climbing, and underwater platforms, focusing on their biological principles, operational capabilities, and specific applications within the wind energy sector.

3.1. The benchmark: capabilities and limitations of conventional robotic systems

To contextualize the contributions of bio-inspired and soft robotics, it is essential to first establish a benchmark based on the current state-of-the-art in conventional robotic systems for wind turbine operations. The incumbent technologies primarily consist of standard multi-rotor Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) for visual inspection and rigid-body crawlers or industrial manipulators for contact-based tasks.

Commercially available multi-rotor UAVs have become the industry standard for rapid visual and thermal screening of turbine blades [8]. Their primary advantages are speed of deployment and the ability to capture high-resolution imagery without physical contact, significantly reducing human risk compared to rope access. However, their operational envelope is constrained by wind conditions; flight in turbulent air, especially near rotating blades, requires significant energy for stabilization, drastically reducing mission endurance and posing collision risks [16]. Furthermore, their rigid structure and reliance on non-contact sensors limit them to detecting surface-level defects, leaving critical subsurface flaws like delaminations or bond-line failures undetected.

For contact-based Non-Destructive Testing (NDT) and repair, “traditional” approaches often involve bespoke rigid-body crawlers. While capable of carrying heavier payloads, these systems often lack the compliance to maintain consistent sensor contact on the complex, curved geometry of a turbine blade, especially in the presence of vibrations. A rigid manipulator attempting to apply a patch or press an ultrasonic transducer against a blade surface requires complex force-feedback control to avoid damaging the delicate composite skin, a task that remains a significant engineering challenge outside of controlled factory environments [17]. These documented limitations in endurance, adaptability to complex surfaces, and safe physical interaction form the critical performance gaps that bio-inspired and soft robotic systems aim to address.

3.2. Aerial platforms (UAVs)

UAVs achieve the highest Technology Readiness Level (TRL 5-6) among autonomous platforms. Over 200 wind farms globally deploy UAV inspection, while fewer than 10 farms use climbing robots. UAVs inspect 2-3 turbines per day compared to 0.5 turbines per day for crawlers. However, UAVs cannot perform contact-based testing or structural repairs. This limits their impact on reducing maintenance costs.

Their promise is evidenced by their higher Technology Readiness Level (TRL 5-6) compared to many other platforms discussed herein and their already widespread commercial use for visual inspection, forming a strong foundation for the integration of more advanced bio-inspired capabilities. However, conventional multi-rotor drones face significant challenges in the gusty, turbulent environments surrounding wind turbines, where wind speeds can vary dramatically within short distances. These conditions lead to platform instability, reduced flight time due to high energy consumption for stabilization, and potential collision risks, ultimately compromising inspection quality and operational safety [16].

To address these limitations, researchers have developed biomimetic UAVs that draw inspiration from the flight capabilities of birds and insects. Avian flight, refined over millions of years of evolution, offers sophisticated solutions for stability and efficiency in turbulent air. Morphing-wing drones, inspired by the adaptive aerodynamics of bird wings, demonstrate superior gust rejection and flight efficiency compared to conventional platforms [19]. Multi-rotors remain superior for precise hovering and stationary positioning during blade inspection. Morphing-wing designs excel in endurance during transit between turbines and maintaining stable flight in moderate turbulence. For routine visual inspection in calm to moderate wind, conventional multi-rotors prove more cost-effective and operationally proven. However, critical analysis reveals significant trade-offs: while flight time can be extended by 15-30% through reduced stabilization energy [6], this comes at the cost of increased mechanical complexity and structural weight.

Current implementations show limited hovering capability, restricting their application to specific inspection scenarios. The convergence in design appears to favor hybrid approaches that combine morphing elements with multi-rotor stability for wind farm applications. This morphing capability reduces the reliance on rapid, energy-intensive motor adjustments, allowing for smoother flight and longer operational endurance, a critical factor for inspecting large wind farms as conceptually illustrated in Fig. 1. Beyond stable flight, a significant challenge for inspection UAVs is achieving close proximity to turbine surfaces for detailed, contact-based non-destructive testing (NDT).

This has spurred the development of bio-inspired perching and adhesion mechanisms. Drawing inspiration from birds of prey and insects, researchers have created UAVs with specialized landing gear capable of securely perching on moving turbine blades. These mechanisms range from articulated claws that grip leading edges to spines that engage with composite surface textures [20]. For adhesive perching, gecko-inspired dry adhesives have been integrated onto UAV feet, creating reversible attachment systems that enable drones to stick to smooth surfaces without consumables or excessive power draw, allowing for stationary sensor deployment and detailed localized inspection [21].

The operational paradigm for inspection is also evolving from single-agent to multi-agent systems. Inspired by the collective behaviors of insect swarms and bird flocks, UAV swarms are being developed for coordinated wind farm inspection. These systems utilize decentralized control algorithms, such as ant colony optimization and flocking rules, to efficiently distribute inspection tasks among multiple drones [22]. This approach significantly reduces the total inspection time for large wind farms and introduces redundancy; if one drone fails, others can complete its assigned tasks. Recent implementations have demonstrated successful autonomous coverage path planning for multiple turbines using swarms of small UAVs communicating via mesh networks [23]. A comparative analysis of these bio-inspired aerial platforms is provided in Table 1.

Furthermore, recent advances in bio-inspired perching mechanisms, summarized in Fig. 2, enable UAVs to achieve stable contact on moving turbine blades for detailed inspection. The integration of biomimetic principles into aerial robotics is fundamentally advancing the capabilities of wind turbine inspection systems. From morphing wings that conquer turbulent winds to swarming algorithms that optimize inspection logistics, these biologically inspired solutions are enhancing the autonomy, efficiency, and safety of wind farm operations. While challenges remain in terms of platform robustness, payload capacity, and certification, the ongoing research and development in this field promise to significantly reduce operational costs and downtime, contributing to the overall economic viability and sustainability of wind energy.

Table 1
Comparison of bio-inspired aerial platforms for wind turbine inspection.

Platform Type	Biological Inspiration	Key Features & Mechanisms	Advantages	Limitations & Challenges
Morphing-Wing UAV [6,19,24,25]	Bird wings (e.g., eagles, albatross)	Variable wing geometry & airfoil Adaptive sweep & twist Compliant structures	Enhanced gust rejection & stability Improved aerodynamic efficiency Reduced power consumption for stabilization	Complex mechanical design & control Higher structural weight Limited hovering capability
Perching UAV [20,21,26]	Birds of prey, insects, geckos	Articulated claws/grippers Micro-spine mechanisms Dry adhesive pads	Enables stationary contact inspection Reduces energy consumption during data collection Allows for precise, close-up NDT	Limited to specific structural features Adhesion performance degrades with surface contamination. Added weight and complexity
UAV Swarms [22,23,27]	Insect swarms, bird flocks	Decentralized control (e.g., ACO, PSO) Local communication & sensing Emergent cooperative behavior	Reduced total inspection time System redundancy & robustness Scalability to large wind farms	Complex inter-agent coordination Communication challenges in GPS-denied environments Limited individual payload capacity
Flapping-Wing UAV (Ornithopter) [28,29]	Birds, insects	Bio-inspired flapping kinematics Active wing morphing Unsteady aerodynamics	High maneuverability in tight spaces Potential for high energy efficiency Resilient to sharp gusts	Low payload capacity Mechanical complexity and fatigue Immature technology (low TRL)

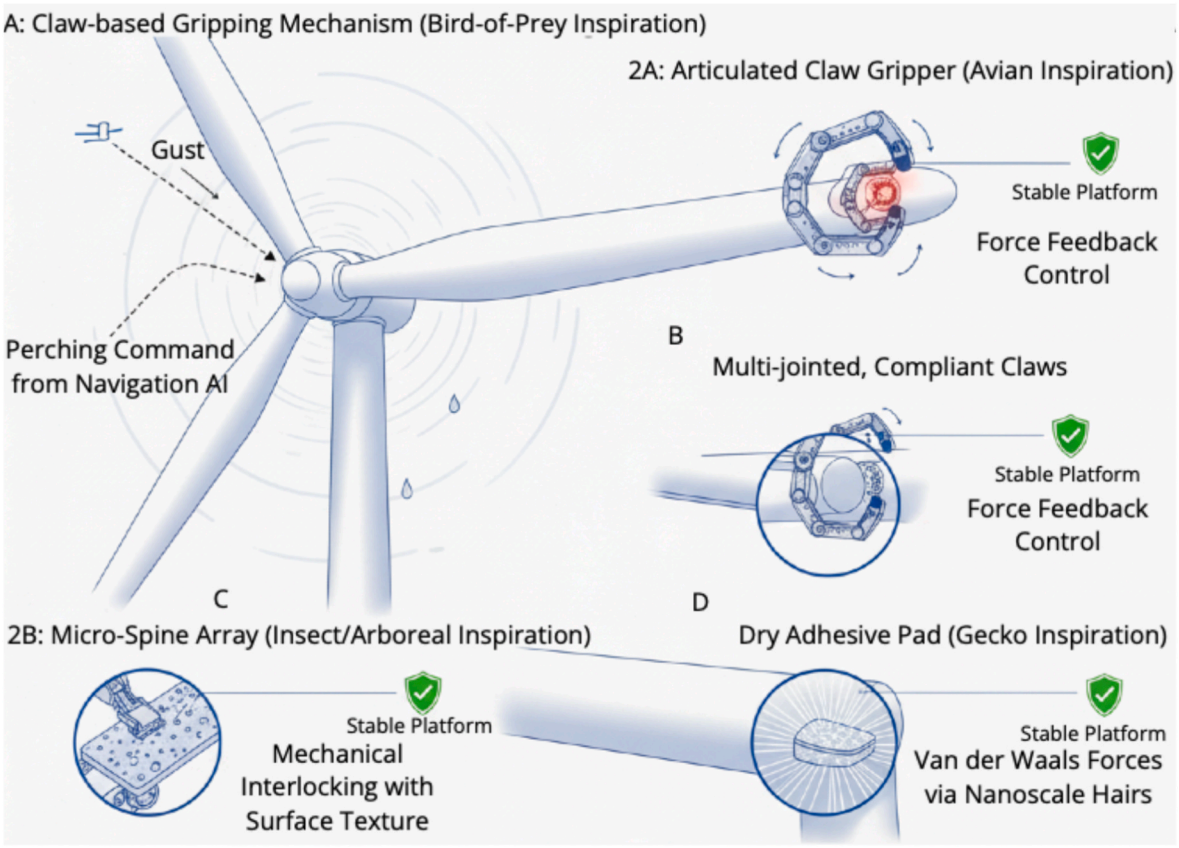


Fig. 2. Bio-inspired UAV perching mechanisms: (A) Articulated claws, (B) Micro-spine arrays, (C) Gecko-inspired dry adhesives.

3.3. Climbing and crawling platforms

While aerial platforms provide rapid access to elevated turbine components, their operational time is inherently limited by battery capacity and susceptibility to high winds. For prolonged, detailed inspection and repair tasks requiring sustained physical contact, climbing and crawling robots present a superior alternative. These platforms can maintain a stationary position for hours, carry heavier payloads such as advanced non-destructive testing (NDT) equipment or repair tools, and operate reliably in the high-vibration, gusty environments that challenge aerial systems. The development of effective climbing robots for wind turbines, which feature vast vertical surfaces (towers) and complex curved geometries (blades), has led to a diverse range of bio-inspired solutions. These systems primarily emulate the locomotion strategies of inchworms, geckos, and snakes to overcome the challenges of gravity, adhesion, and navigation on varied surfaces. Climbing robots address the distinct challenges of prolonged, contact-based work by emulating the locomotion of inchworms, geckos, and snakes. The various approaches, summarized in Table 2, represent a trade-off between adhesion strength and surface compatibility.

For the ferromagnetic steel towers, magnetic and Gripper-Based Systems inspired by inchworms provide reliable, high-strength adhesion that is largely unaffected by surface moisture [30]. Their primary limitation, however, is their fundamental incompatibility with the

Table 2
Comparison of bio-inspired climbing platforms for wind turbine access.

Platform Type	Biological Inspiration	Adhesion Principle	Target Turbine Component	Key Advantages	Key Limitations	TRL
Magnetic Inchworm	Inchworm, Caterpillar	Magnetic Force (Permanent/Electro)	Steel Tower, Nacelle	High reliability on ferrous surfaces; robust to contamination.	Ineffective on composites; high weight/power consumption.	6-7
Gecko-Inspired Crawler	Gecko Lizard	Van der Waals Forces (Dry Adhesion)	Composite Blades, Concrete Towers	Silent, low-power, and safe for delicate surfaces.	Performance degraded by dust, moisture, and surface oils.	4-5
Articulated Snake Robot	Snakes	Bracing & Gripping with Body Structure	Internal Blades, Tower Interiors	Unparalleled access to confined, complex spaces.	Slow speed; high mechanical and control complexity.	5-6

composite materials of turbine blades, creating a critical operational gap. To fill this gap, adhesion-based systems inspired by geckos leverage van der Waals forces to enable strong, reversible adhesion on the smooth, non-ferrous surfaces of composite blades [48]. This method offers silent, low-power operation that eliminates the risk of surface damage, but its performance is highly susceptible to contamination from the dust, pollen, and moisture common in wind farm environments [49]. Finally, Snake-Inspired articulated robots offer unparalleled access to confined internal spaces, such as the inside of a blade, using serpentine locomotion to navigate geometries that are inaccessible to other platforms [50]. Their mechanical complexity and slow speed, however, make them unsuitable for covering large external areas.

Beyond these two primary categories, snake-inspired articulated robots offer a unique solution for navigating the most complex and confined geometries of a wind turbine's interior, such as the inside of a blade or the box girder within the tower. Inspired by the serpentine locomotion of snakes, these robots consist of multiple rigid segments connected by active joints, allowing them to achieve a variety of gaits, including rectilinear, sidewinding, and rolling motion. This hyper-redundant kinematics enables them to twist through narrow access hatches and conform to the intricate internal rib structure of a blade for detailed inspection. Showcased a snake robot that could autonomously map the interior of a wind turbine blade using LiDAR, identifying internal structural defects unreachable by other platforms [50]. While their mechanical complexity and relatively slow speed are disadvantages for covering large external areas, their unparalleled access to confined internal spaces makes them an invaluable tool for specific, high-detail inspection scenarios where other platforms cannot operate.

The integration of these climbing platforms into a cohesive operational framework is a key research frontier. Future systems may involve heterogeneous teams, where a UAV delivers a micro-spine crawler to a specific damaged location on a blade, or a magnetic inchworm robot

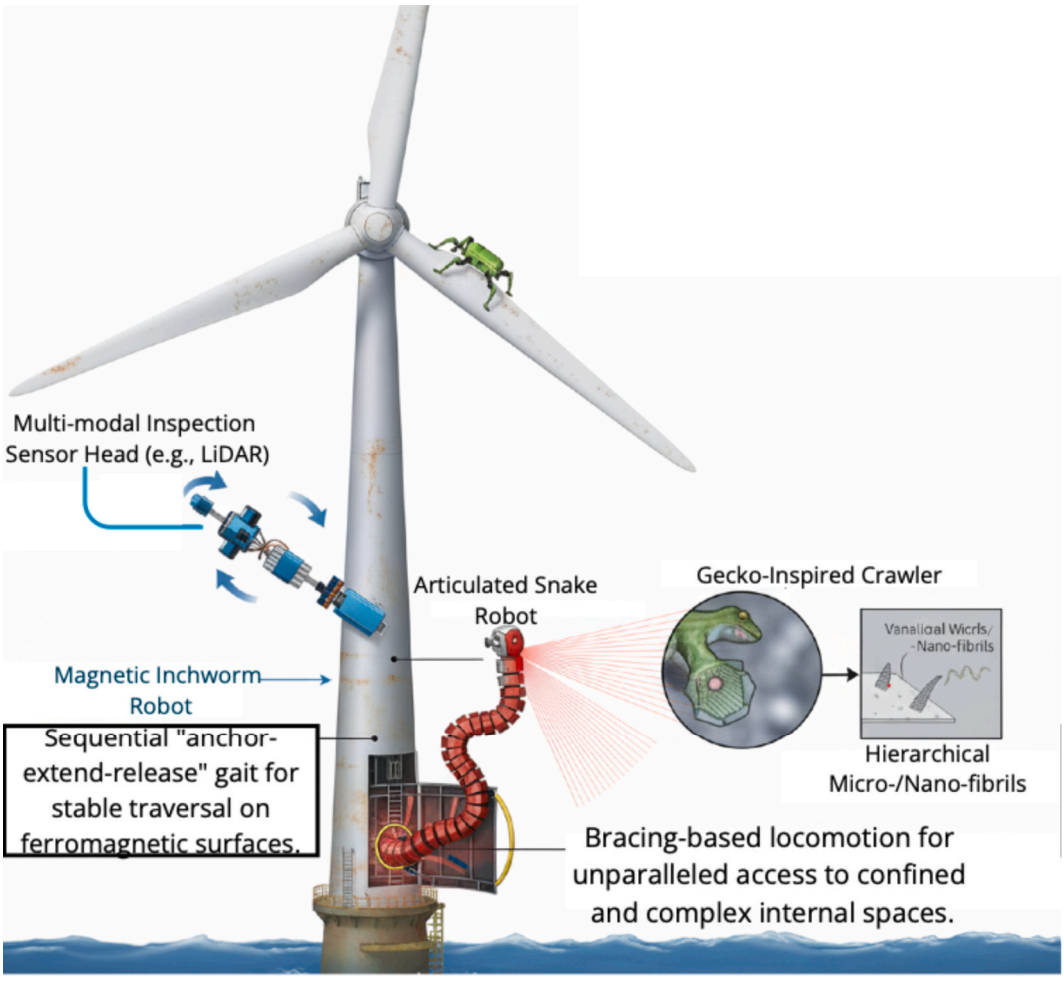


Fig. 3. Conceptual illustration of bio-inspired climbing robots on a wind turbine: a magnetic inchworm on the tower, a gecko-inspired crawler on the blade, and an articulated snake robot accessing an internal space.

deploys a snake-like robot for an internal inspection. The development of shared power autonomy solutions, such as inductive charging stations installed on the turbine itself, is also critical for enabling long-term deployment of these robotic inspectors. The key characteristics of these climbing platforms are compared in Table 2. The application of these robots for comprehensive turbine access is conceptually illustrated in Fig. 3. Technology Readiness Levels (TRLs) were assigned based on a systematic framework considering (1) environmental validation (lab vs. field testing), (2) operational duration and autonomy, (3) system reliability and repeatability, and (4) technology maturity in commercial applications. TRL 3-4 indicates laboratory validation, TRL 5-6 represents prototype testing in relevant environments, and TRL 7-9 signifies system demonstration in operational environments through commercial deployment.

Climbing and crawling platforms fill a critical niche in the robotic O&M ecosystem for wind energy. By drawing inspiration from nature's most adept climbers, these robots provide the stable, long-duration physical presence required for thorough inspection and precise repair. While each type has its optimal use case, ongoing research into hybrid adhesion mechanisms, improved material durability, and enhanced autonomy is steadily pushing the Technology Readiness Level (TRL) of these systems higher, paving the way for their widespread adoption in the wind energy industry. A proposed technology roadmap to guide this development is presented in Fig. 8.

3.3.1. Comparative analysis of bio-inspired climbing mechanisms

Climbing robots employ three primary bio-inspired adhesion strategies. Each offers distinct performance characteristics and optimal use cases. We provide a critical comparative analysis to guide technology selection.

Magnetic Adhesion Systems dominate current deployments on steel tower structures. These inchworm-inspired robots offer adhesion forces exceeding 500 N with minimal power consumption. Field trials at offshore installations demonstrate 95% reliability over 100+ climb cycles. However, their fundamental limitation creates a critical operational gap: complete ineffectiveness on non-ferromagnetic composite blade surfaces. Electromagnetic variants consume 15-25 W continuously, reducing mission duration by 40-60% compared to passive adhesion methods.

Gecko-inspired dry adhesion addresses the composite blade challenge through van der Waals forces. This enables reversible attachment on smooth non-metallic surfaces without power consumption during adhesion. Laboratory demonstrations show adhesion strengths of 50-100 N on pristine composite panels. Field deployment reveals severe performance degradation. Dust accumulation reduces adhesion by 60-80% within 2-3 h of outdoor operation. Moisture and surface oils can eliminate adhesion entirely. The need for frequent cleaning every 30-60 min undermines autonomous operation claims. The current TRL remains at 3-4 despite optimistic laboratory results.

Snake-inspired articulated systems offer unmatched access to confined internal geometries within blade structures. These systems use distributed contact points rather than concentrated adhesion. Their hyper-redundant design enables navigation through 20-30 cm access ports and around internal structural ribs. The primary limitation is speed: serpentine locomotion achieves only 2-5 cm/s compared to 10-20 cm/s for inchworm climbers. This makes them unsuitable for large external surface coverage but ideal for targeted internal inspection missions.

3.4. Underwater and transitional platforms for offshore foundations

The expansion of wind energy into deeper offshore environments necessitates a corresponding evolution in the methods for inspecting and maintaining the submerged and intertidal portions of the support structures. These foundations, including monopiles, jackets, and gravity-based structures are subjected to a uniquely harsh combination of hydrodynamic forces, biofouling, and corrosive seawater. Conventional inspection methods, predominantly reliant on remotely operated vehicles (ROVs) operated from support vessels and human divers, are profoundly expensive, weather-dependent, and hazardous. The high day-rates for specialized vessels and the limited operational windows for divers create a significant bottleneck and a major contributor to the Levelized Cost of Energy (LCOE) for offshore wind [2,51].

The operational environment for these robots is exceptionally demanding. Underwater, they must contend with currents that can displace them from the structure, low visibility that degrades optical sensors, and the omnipresent risk of entanglement in marine growth. The transition zone, alternately exposed to air and submerged in aerated, turbulent water, presents one of the most corrosive and physically chaotic environments. Traditional ROVs, while powerful, often rely on expensive, heavy thrusters for station-keeping, consuming substantial energy and creating complex wake dynamics that can disturb sensors. Their rigid manipulators, effective for heavy-duty tasks, lack the delicate touch required for sensitive inspection or for interacting with bio-fouled surfaces without causing damage. Bio-inspired approaches, conversely, offer pathways to energy-efficient locomotion, robust adhesion in flowing water, and compliant, adaptive manipulation, drawing on millions of years of evolutionary refinement in aquatic and amphibious life.

3.4.1. Magnetic and suction-based crawlers for foundation inspection

This section critically reviews the emerging paradigms in biomimetic and soft robotics designed specifically for the challenges of offshore wind foundations. It moves beyond a simple catalog of robots to analyze the underlying biological principles, their engineered implementation, and their comparative advantages and limitations in real-world scenarios (see Table 3). The discussion is structured around the two primary strategies for achieving stable contact and mobility on submerged structures, which mirror and extend the principles used in aerial and climbing robots.

3.4.2. Fish-inspired underwater vehicles for scour assessment

The relentless push for offshore wind energy into deeper, more exposed marine environments has shifted a significant portion of the operational risk and cost to the submerged support structures. These foundation monopiles, jackets, and gravity-based systems are perpetually subjected to a corrosive cocktail of hydrodynamic loading, abrasive sediments, and pervasive biofouling, all of which threaten their structural integrity over a project's 25-year lifespan. A critical and ongoing threat to the stability of monopile and jacket foundations is scour the erosion of seabed sediment around the base of the structure due to complex vortex shedding and accelerated flow. Left unchecked, scour can compromise foundation integrity and lead to catastrophic structural failure. Monitoring scour is therefore paramount, but it is challenging with conventional tools.

Here, fish-inspired underwater vehicles offer a transformative solution. Drawing inspiration from the streamlined bodies and highly efficient propulsion mechanisms of species like tuna and salmon, these biomimetic underwater vehicles (BUVs) utilize body and/or caudal fin (BCF) propulsion rather than rotary thrusters. This bio-inspired locomotion is not merely an aesthetic choice; it confers significant advantages for scour assessment missions. BCF propulsion is inherently more energy-efficient than thruster-based systems, enabling longer deployment times for persistent monitoring [18,52]. Furthermore, the undulatory motion creates a less turbulent wake compared to the chaotic wash from propellers, which is crucial for two reasons: it prevents the robot's own thrust from artificially disturbing the scour hole it is trying to measure, and it allows for closer proximity to the seabed and foundation for high-resolution sensor data collection without kicking up sediment that would blind optical sensors [53].

Critical Assessment: No single climbing platform satisfies all wind turbine access requirements. The mature choice for steel tower

Table 3
Comparison of bio-inspired underwater platforms for foundation inspection.

Platform Type	Biological Inspiration	Adhesion Principle	Target Foundation	Key Advantages	Key Limitations	TRL
Magnetic Inchworm [30,31,32]	Inchworm, Caterpillar	Magnetic Force (Permanent/ Electro)	Steel Monopiles, Jackets	High reliability on ferrous surfaces; robust to biofouling & low visibility; High payload capacity.	Ineffective on concrete/composites; high weight/power consumption; Risk of uncontrolled adhesion.	4-5
Suction-Based Crawler [33,34]	Octopus, Remora Fish	Negative Pressure (Suction)	Concrete, Coated Steel, Complex Geometries	Surface-agnostic adhesion; safe for coatings; Controllable attachment/detachment.	Performance is degraded by rough/ biofouled surfaces; Can require continuous power for seal maintenance.	3-4
Soft Robotic Gripper (Manipulator) [34, 35]	Octopus Arm, Sea Star	Conformable Gripping & Suction	General Manipulation, Valve Turning	Exceptional adaptability to object shape, delicate handling, and innately safe interaction.	Limited force exertion; can be slow; Challenging control of hyper-redundant structures.	4-5

inspection remains magnetic systems despite power consumption. For composite blade surfaces, the technology gap persists. Gecko adhesion requires fundamental breakthroughs in contamination resistance before deployment viability. The realistic near-term solution may involve hybrid approaches: UAV-deployed microclimbers for small surface areas combined with rope-access technicians for major interventions, rather than the fully autonomous climbing robot vision often presented.

Alternative approaches include legged platforms. Developed hexapod robots inspired by insect locomotion. These demonstrate stable walking on vibrating offshore platform surfaces where adhesion-based approaches struggle. The distributed contact points (six legs) provide inherent stability during turbine operation. Single-contact climbing mechanisms can slip during high-amplitude vibration events. However, legged systems face limitations in traversing smooth blade surfaces and vertical tower sections. This positions them as complementary to adhesion-based climbers rather than replacements. Their primary niche may be nacelle-level inspection where flat walking surfaces exist and vibration resistance proves paramount.

3.4.3. Integration and future outlook

The future of offshore foundation inspection likely lies not in a single robotic platform, but in heterogeneous robotic teams and multimodal systems. A compelling vision involves a mothership ROV, itself potentially bio-inspired for efficient propulsion (e.g., tuna-inspired), deploying a swarm of smaller magnetic or adhesion-based crawlers to inspect large areas of a jacket structure simultaneously. These crawlers could be equipped with shared docking stations on the foundation itself for inductive charging and data uplink, enabling persistent, months-long monitoring campaigns. Furthermore, the next frontier is the development of true transitional robots that can move seamlessly between water and air. This is inspired by amphibians and diving birds.

Such a capability would be revolutionary for inspecting the splash zone, which is notoriously difficult for both purely aquatic and purely aerial robots. Early research includes robots with morphing propellers or wings that can function in both media and robots that use water jets to propel themselves out of the water for a brief aerial phase [18]. While these are at a low TRL (1-3), they represent the kind of disruptive, bio-inspired thinking required to fully conquer the challenging environment of offshore wind farms. The application of bio-inspired and soft robotics to underwater and transitional platforms for offshore wind foundations is a vibrant and critically important research frontier.

By drawing inspiration from the adhesion and locomotion strategies of octopuses, remoras, and inchworms, engineers are creating robots that offer the potential for safer, more frequent, and more cost-effective inspections. This will be essential for ensuring the structural integrity and extending the operational lifespan of the massive offshore wind infrastructure required for the global energy transition. While significant challenges in power, reliability, and autonomy remain, the trajectory of research points towards a future where resilient, adaptive robotic systems are permanently integrated into the wind farm ecosystem, continuously safeguarding our renewable energy investments beneath the waves.

4. Bio-inspired sensing, navigation, and autonomy in GPS-denied environments

The operational environment of a wind farm presents one of the most challenging scenarios for robotic autonomy: a vast, structurally complex, and dynamically turbulent space where Global Navigation Satellite Systems (GNSS) signals are frequently occluded or reflected, creating an effectively GPS-denied environment. This problem is further compounded by perceptual degradation caused by adverse weather conditions, lighting variations, and the repetitive, feature-poor surfaces of turbine structures. Conventional robotic navigation systems, which rely heavily on waypoint-based GNSS guidance and pre-programmed paths, fail catastrophically in this setting. To achieve the level of resilience required for persistent autonomous operations, the wind energy sector is increasingly turning to biological systems, which have evolved over millions of years to navigate complex, dynamic, and uncertain environments without any external positioning infrastructure. This section delves into the cutting-edge domain of bio-inspired sensing, navigation, and autonomy, synthesizing principles from animal cognition, insect swarming, and avian perception to create robust frameworks for robotic operation in the challenging airspace and surfaces of wind farms. The integration of these biologically grounded strategies is not merely an alternative but a fundamental necessity for unlocking the full potential of autonomous inspection and repair, moving beyond fragile, prescripted missions towards adaptive, resilient, and intelligent robotic behaviors.

4.1. Sensor fusion for perception and localization

At the core of autonomous operation in GPS-denied environments lies the challenge of perceptual understanding and ego-motion estimation, the robot's ability to answer the fundamental questions, “What do my surroundings look like?” and “Where am I within it?” Biological organisms excel at this through multi-modal sensory integration and predictive filtering. A hawk, for instance, does not rely on a single sense; it fuses high-acuity visual input with auditory cues and even magnetic field perception to build a rich, robust model of its environment and its trajectory within it. Emulating this, robotic sensor fusion architectures for wind turbines integrate data from a suite of complementary sensors, visual cameras, LiDAR, inertial measurement units (IMUs), ultrasonic sensors, and sometimes millimeter-wave radar to create a coherent and reliable state estimate.

Operating in GPS-denied wind farm environments requires robust perception systems that fuse data from multiple sensors, such as visual cameras, LiDAR, and inertial measurement units (IMUs). The computational foundation for this often involves Bayesian estimation theory, with algorithms like Kalman Filters providing efficient recursive state estimation [54]. While the *principle* of multi-modal sensing is bio-inspired, the specific algorithms (Kalman Filters and particle filters)

are well-established engineering techniques. Their application is crucial for tasks like visual-inertial odometry (VIO), which enables UAVs to maintain accurate pose estimation when GPS signals are lost near massive turbine structures. For visual-inertial odometry (VIVO) on UAVs, this approach enables smooth and accurate pose estimation by combining high-frequency IMU data with visual features from cameras, providing reliable navigation where GPS signals are occluded or reflected by massive turbine structures [54].

In particularly challenging scenarios with ambiguous data associations, such as distinguishing between identical-looking turbine towers or navigating in low-visibility conditions, particle filters offer enhanced robustness through a 'survival of the fittest' approach. This bio-inspired strategy maintains multiple simultaneous state hypotheses, progressively favoring those that best explain the sensor measurements. This computational paradigm proves especially valuable during close-proximity inspection tasks, where the likelihood of perceptual aliasing is high and traditional filtering approaches may converge on incorrect state estimates [55]. Bio-inspired filtering strategies enable robotic systems to maintain accurate localization and navigation even when traditional positioning systems fail. This capability is fundamental for achieving persistent autonomous operations.

Beyond filtering, the most critical capability for long-term autonomy is Simultaneous Localization and Mapping (SLAM). Beyond filtering, the most critical capability for long-term autonomy is Simultaneous Localization and Mapping (SLAM), which enables robots to build maps of unknown environments while tracking their own position within those maps. Modern SLAM solutions represent the robot's trajectory and environment map as interconnected nodes in a computational graph, where sensor measurements progressively constrain possible locations. Visual SLAM systems extract distinctive features from camera images to create sparse but recognizable landmark maps, while LiDAR SLAM uses precise geometric point clouds to create dense, metrically accurate maps ideal for the large-scale structures of wind farms. However, pure geometric SLAM struggles in environments with repetitive structures common in wind turbines, where identical towers or blade sections can confuse location recognition. To address this, bio-inspired visual place recognition using deep learning generates robust scene descriptors that remain consistent across viewpoint and lighting changes, dramatically improving the reliability of recognizing previously visited locations and correcting accumulated positional errors.

Visual SLAM systems, such as ORB-SLAM3, extract distinctive visual features from camera images and use them as landmarks, providing sparse but highly discriminative maps that excel at recognizing specific locations [56]. LiDAR SLAM uses precise geometric point clouds to create dense, metrically accurate maps ideal for large-scale wind farm structures. The fundamental challenge for both approaches in wind farms is repetitive geometry, where multiple identical turbine towers can cause confusion. Drawing from the visual place recognition capabilities of rodents and insects, researchers have developed deep learning-based loop closure detection systems that use convolutional neural Networks to generate robust scene descriptors that remain consistent across viewpoint and lighting changes, dramatically improving location recognition reliability and correcting accumulated positional drift [57]. Sensor fusion also extends to the challenging problem of wind estimation and gust rejection, a critical factor for stable flight near turbines. Inspired by the sensitive mechanoreceptors in bird wings that detect airflow, researchers are developing methods to fuse traditional IMU data with measurements from onboard airspeed sensors and even the control inputs required to reject disturbances to estimate the local wind field. This estimated wind vector can then be incorporated into the robot's motion model within the Kalman Filter framework, leading to more accurate predictions and enhanced flight stability in the turbulent wind farm environment [58]. A generalized architecture for such a bio-inspired sensor fusion framework is shown in Fig. 4. The resulting system is a sophisticated, multi-layered architecture of Bayesian estimators and optimization routines that, much like a biological brain, continuously fuses noisy, asynchronous sensory streams into a stable and actionable perception of the world—a foundational capability for any autonomous agent tasked with navigating the complex and unforgiving landscape of a wind energy facility.

4.1.1. *Vision-based systems (insect-inspired optical flow)*

Drawing inspiration from the neural mechanisms of flying insects, vision-based navigation systems leverage optical flow, the pattern of apparent motion of visual scenes caused by relative movement between an observer and their environment. Insects like honeybees demonstrate

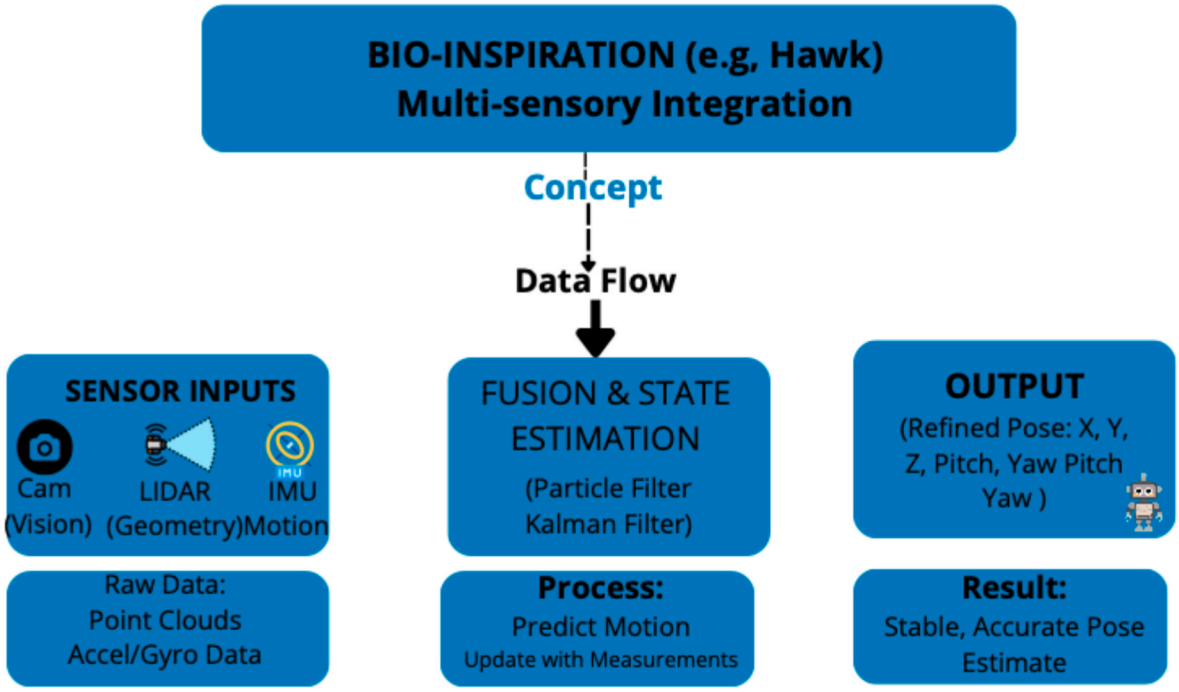


Fig. 4. A block diagram of a bio-inspired sensor fusion framework.

remarkable navigation capabilities using minimal neural processing, estimating distance and avoiding obstacles by measuring how quickly visual features move across their compound eyes. For robotic applications in wind farms, this translates to estimating robot motion by analyzing apparent movement patterns in sequential images captured by onboard cameras. This bio-inspired approach enables UAVs to maintain safe distances from turbine surfaces, regulate flight speed, and execute precise landing maneuvers without requiring complex 3D reconstruction or prior environmental maps, proving particularly valuable in the visually repetitive and texture-poor environments characteristic of wind energy facilities [59].

4.1.2. LiDAR and sonar sensing (Bat-inspired echolocation)

Echolocation strategies employed by bats and cetaceans provide the biological blueprint for active ranging systems using LiDAR and sonar in GPS-denied wind farm environments. Bats navigate complex environments and capture prey in complete darkness by emitting ultrasonic chirps and analyzing returning echoes to construct detailed mental maps of their surroundings. This biological capability translates to time-of-flight measurement principles, where distance is determined by measuring how long a signal takes to return after bouncing off an object. For LiDAR systems, this enables precise 3D point cloud generation through laser scanning, creating detailed geometric maps. Sonar systems, while lower resolution, provide complementary capabilities particularly valuable in adverse weather conditions where optical sensors fail, using signal processing to extract faint echoes from noisy returns. By fusing these active sensing modalities, robotic systems achieve robust perception in the visually degraded and structurally complex environments of wind turbine interiors and exteriors, enabling reliable obstacle avoidance and path planning even in complete darkness or through obscurants like mist and dust [60].

4.2. Bio-inspired algorithms for path planning and swarm coordination

The operational complexity of wind farm environments demands sophisticated planning and coordination strategies that transcend conventional algorithmic approaches. In these vast, dynamic spaces characterized by turbulent airflow, complex geometry, and communication constraints, traditional centralized planning systems exhibit critical vulnerabilities, including single-point failures, computational bottlenecks, and inability to adapt to rapidly changing conditions. Biological systems, through millions of years of evolutionary refinement, have developed remarkably efficient decentralized strategies for navigation, resource allocation, and collective decision-making that maintain robustness even with limited individual capabilities. This section explores the transformative potential of bio-inspired computational paradigms drawing from social insect colonies, flocking birds, and neural processing principles to create autonomous systems capable of resilient operation in the challenging context of wind energy facilities. By encoding biological principles into mathematical frameworks, these approaches enable emergent intelligent behaviors that are adaptive, scalable, and fault-tolerant, addressing fundamental limitations of pre-programmed navigation strategies while providing the computational foundation for large-scale autonomous inspection and maintenance operations.

Bio-inspired path planning approaches fundamentally differ from conventional methods by enabling optimality to emerge from simple local rules rather than global computation. Conventional approaches typically use graph search algorithms like A* or sampling-based methods like Rapidly-exploring Random Trees to find optimal paths from start to goal while avoiding obstacles. However, these methods struggle with dynamic environments and multi-agent coordination. Bio-inspired algorithms instead draw from natural systems where swarms of individuals, each following simple interaction rules based on their local neighbors, collectively achieve efficient global coordination. This decentralized approach mirrors organizational principles found in bird flocks, fish schools, and insect colonies, where complex group behaviors emerge without centralized control [61].

4.2.1. Swarm intelligence (ant colony, particle swarm) for multi-robot coverage

Social insects such as ants, bees, and termites exhibit astonishing collective capabilities despite possessing limited individual cognitive capacity. This phenomenon, known as swarm intelligence, has inspired computational frameworks that enable groups of simple robots to achieve complex tasks through local interactions and stigmergic communication (indirect coordination through modification of the environment). In the context of wind farm operations, swarm intelligence principles provide powerful mechanisms for optimizing multi-robot inspection coverage, resource allocation, and adaptive task allocation without requiring centralized control or global communication infrastructure. Ant Colony Optimization (ACO) for coverage path planning models the pheromone-based foraging behavior of ants, where artificial pheromone values associated with path segments are iteratively updated to reinforce promising solutions. Each robot probabilistically chooses its next move based on both pheromone strength (reflecting paths successful robots have taken) and path desirability (typically based on distance). The pheromone update incorporates both evaporation to avoid premature convergence and reinforcement based on solution quality.

This creates a positive feedback loop where shorter paths receive stronger reinforcement, leading to the emergence of optimal coverage patterns across the wind farm. For inspection tasks, this translates to efficient area coverage while minimizing redundant visits to already-inspected regions, with the additional advantage of inherent adaptability to dynamic constraints such as changing wind conditions or unexpected obstacles [62]. Particle Swarm Optimization (PSO) adopts a different biological metaphor inspired by the flocking behavior of birds and schools of fish. In PSO-based multi-robot coordination, each robot maintains its current trajectory and adjusts it based on two factors: its own best-found solution (personal experience) and the best solution discovered by neighboring robots (social learning). This balance between individual experience and collective knowledge enables swarms to coordinate inspection coverage while avoiding redundant overlap. For wind farm applications, this framework enables efficient distribution of inspection tasks across multiple UAVs while maintaining collision avoidance through repulsive potential fields incorporated into the velocity update. The emergent behavior allows the swarm to dynamically redistribute tasks when robots fail or when inspection priorities change, ensuring complete coverage of all turbine surfaces while optimizing overall mission duration and energy consumption. Experimental validations in simulated wind farm environments have demonstrated that PSO-based coordination can reduce total inspection time by 30-45% compared to systematic coverage patterns while maintaining robustness to individual robot failures [63].

The integration of these swarm intelligence approaches creates a multi-layered coordination framework where ACO handles path optimization and coverage completeness while PSO manages dynamic task allocation and resource balancing. This hybrid approach mirrors the multi-modal coordination observed in social insect colonies, where different mechanisms operate at different temporal and spatial scales to achieve collective objectives. Mathematical analysis of such systems typically employs Lyapunov stability theory and Markov chain models to prove convergence properties and characterize emergent behaviors. For a swarm of N robots operating in a wind farm with M turbines, the state space of the collective system has dimensionality that grows exponentially with N, yet through appropriate design of local interaction rules, the system converges to desirable global patterns with provable guarantees on coverage completeness and mission duration [64].

4.2.2. Neural network and Fuzzy Logic Controllers for adaptive navigation

While swarm intelligence provides powerful coordination

mechanisms, individual robots require robust navigation controllers capable of adapting to the complex and dynamic wind farm environment. Biological nervous systems offer inspiration through their ability to process noisy sensory information, learn from experience, and generate appropriate motor commands in real-time. Two particularly influential paradigms from computational intelligence, neural networks and fuzzy logic systems, provide mathematical frameworks for implementing these biological principles in robotic navigation systems, enabling adaptive behaviors that transcend the limitations of conventional control approaches. Artificial Neural Networks (ANNs) for navigation control model the information processing principles of biological neurons through layered networks of simple processing units. These networks learn to map sensor inputs to control outputs through multiple layers of nonlinear transformations, with each layer extracting progressively more abstract features. For navigation in wind farms, the input vector x typically includes LiDAR point cloud features, optical flow vectors, IMU readings, and wind estimates, while the output vector y contains actuator commands or waypoint adjustments. Through supervised learning on labeled demonstration data or reinforcement learning through trial-and-error, these networks learn to approximate complex control policies that would be difficult to specify manually. Deep reinforcement learning frameworks enable robots to learn navigation policies through trial-and-error interaction with their environment. The robot learns to associate sensor observations with optimal control actions by receiving rewards for successful behaviors and penalties for failures. When combined with deep neural networks, this approach enables learning sophisticated navigation policies directly from high-dimensional sensory inputs like camera images and LiDAR scans. This approach has demonstrated remarkable success in enabling UAVs to navigate through complex environments while avoiding obstacles and compensating for wind disturbances, with performance often surpassing conventional control approaches in scenarios with significant uncertainty and partial observability [65]. Fuzzy Logic Controllers (FLCs) provide an alternative bio-inspired approach that mimics the approximate reasoning capabilities of human cognition rather than neural information processing.

Unlike classical logic systems that require precise binary truth values, fuzzy logic operates on continuous truth values in the range [0,1], enabling graceful handling of uncertainty and imprecise sensor measurements. A fuzzy logic controller for UAV navigation consists of four main components: fuzzification (converting sensor measurements into linguistic terms like “high wind speed” or “medium distance”), a fuzzy inference engine (applying IF-THEN rules like “IF wind_speed IS high AND distance_to_turbine IS medium THEN adjust_heading moderately”), a rule base (a collection of these conditional statements), and defuzzification (converting linguistic outputs back into specific control commands). For wind farm navigation, fuzzy controllers excel at implementing heuristic knowledge from human operators, such as strategies for approaching turbines at different wind conditions or rules for recovering from gust disturbances. The transparency of the rule base facilitates verification and certification, a critical consideration for safety-critical applications, while the continuous nature of the inference process results in smooth control actions even with noisy sensor inputs. Research has shown that fuzzy navigation controllers can maintain stable flight in turbulent conditions where conventional PID controllers exhibit significant performance degradation, particularly during close-proximity inspection maneuvers where wind effects are most pronounced [66].

The integration of neural networks and fuzzy logic creates powerful hybrid systems that leverage the strengths of both approaches. Neuro-fuzzy systems employ neural learning algorithms to automatically generate and refine fuzzy rules from operational data, combining the transparency and interpretability of fuzzy systems with the adaptive learning capabilities of neural networks. Adaptive Neuro-Fuzzy Inference Systems (ANFIS) implement this integration through a five-layer network architecture that is functionally equivalent to a Takagi-Sugeno fuzzy inference system but can be trained using gradient descent or hybrid learning algorithms. For wind farm navigation, ANFIS controllers can initially implement basic rules from human experts, then continuously refine these rules through operational experience, gradually improving performance while maintaining interpretability. Mathematical analysis of these systems typically employs universal approximation theorems to establish their representational capabilities and Lyapunov stability analysis to verify closed-loop performance guarantees [67].

Experimental validation of these bio-inspired control approaches in both simulation and field tests has demonstrated significant advantages over conventional methods. In comprehensive studies comparing navigation performance in simulated wind farm environments, neural network controllers achieved a 25-40% reduction in position tracking error during gust rejection tasks compared to optimal linear controllers, while fuzzy logic systems reduced collision rates during close-proximity inspection by 60% compared to traditional obstacle avoidance algorithms. More importantly, these bio-inspired approaches exhibited graceful performance degradation under sensor failures and environmental disturbances, maintaining basic operational capability even when operating outside their designed parameters, a characteristic of biological systems that is highly desirable for autonomous operations in unpredictable environments like wind farms [68]. The application of swarm intelligence for coordinated wind farm inspection is depicted in Fig. 5.

The combination of swarm intelligence for multi-robot coordination with neural and fuzzy systems for individual navigation creates a comprehensive bio-inspired autonomy framework that addresses the full spectrum of challenges in wind farm operations. This integrated approach mirrors the hierarchical organization found in biological systems, where local reflexes and adaptive behaviors operate in concert with collective decision-making processes to achieve robust operation in complex, dynamic environments. As wind energy facilities continue to grow in scale and complexity, these bio-inspired algorithms will play an increasingly critical role in enabling the autonomous systems necessary for efficient and cost-effective operations and maintenance. However, transitioning from homogenous swarms to heterogeneous teams (e.g., a mothership UAV coordinating with climbing crawlers and underwater vehicles) introduces significant integration challenges. Currently, there is a profound lack of unified standards for cross-platform communication protocols, decentralized task allocation mechanisms, and inter-domain failover strategies. Future research must develop robust, hardware-agnostic middleware that allows an aerial drone to seamlessly hand off inspection tasks to a blade crawler, ensuring the system can autonomously reallocate resources or trigger human intervention if one platform experiences a failure.

5. Contact-based inspection and robotic repair

The transition from visual, non-contact surveys to precise, contact-based inspection and repair represents the frontier of autonomous wind farm operations. While aerial drones excel at rapid, initial blade screening, many critical defects such as subsurface delaminations, microcracks, and bond-line failures require physical contact with advanced Non-Destructive Testing (NDT) sensors to be detected. Similarly, effective repair demands precise material deposition or manipulation on often complex, curved surfaces. This chapter delves into the integration of advanced NDT methodologies with robotic manipulators, highlighting how bio-inspired and soft robotic systems are uniquely positioned to overcome the limitations of conventional robotic arms in these delicate, contact-based tasks.

5.1. Advanced non-destructive testing (NDT) using robotic manipulators

The accurate assessment of a wind turbine's structural health, particularly the composite blades, which are subject to complex fatigue

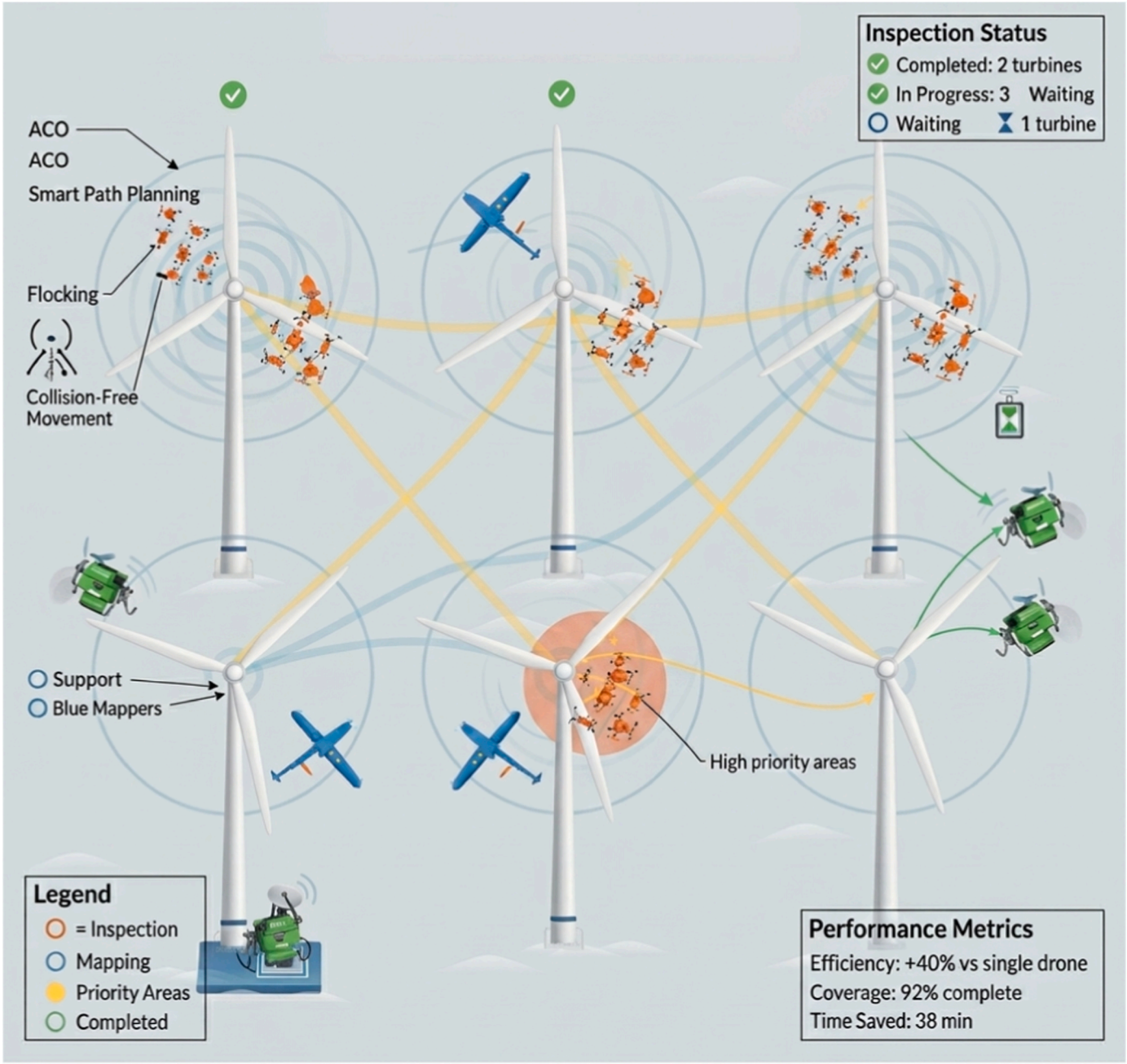


Fig. 5. Block diagram of a bio-inspired multi-sensor fusion framework for autonomous navigation in GPS-denied wind farm environments.

loads and erosion, hinges on the application of sophisticated NDT techniques. Methods such as ultrasonic testing, phased array ultrasonics, eddy current testing, and thermography are industry standards for detecting internal flaws. However, their efficacy is critically dependent on maintaining consistent, optimal contact and orientation between the sensor probe and the component's surface, a challenge that is magnified on the vast, vertically oriented, and variably curved surfaces of a turbine blade or tower. Manual application of these techniques requires technicians to be suspended at great heights, a slow, hazardous, and weather-dependent process. Traditional industrial robots, with their rigid limbs and high-impedance actuators, are ill-suited for this task; they lack the compliance to conform to surface irregularities, risking damage to both the delicate sensor and the blade's composite skin, and they struggle to maintain a consistent contact force in the presence of platform vibration or wind-induced movement.

The emergence of soft robotic manipulators and bio-inspired control strategies is directly addressing these challenges, enabling a new paradigm of robust and sensitive robotic NDT. The fundamental advantage lies in embodied compliance. Drawing inspiration from the muscular hydrostats of octopus arms or the delicate legs of insects, soft robotic manipulators can be constructed from compliant, continuously deformable materials like elastomers. This inherent flexibility allows them to passively conform to the complex curvature of a wind turbine blade, ensuring a large contact area and uniform pressure distribution without the need for complex, real-time force feedback control for every minor surface irregularity [69]. This passive conformity is a form of embodied intelligence that drastically simplifies the control architecture. For instance, a soft manipulator equipped with an ultrasonic transducer can be pressed against a blade surface, and its compliant body will naturally distribute the force, maintaining the necessary acoustic coupling for the ultrasound to penetrate the composite material effectively, even as the robot traverses over a leading edge or a region

with a changing radius of curvature [70]. This stands in stark contrast to a rigid robotic arm, which would require a complex, actively controlled force/torque sensor at its wrist and a high-bandwidth control loop to achieve the same result, a system that is both more expensive and more susceptible to instability upon encountering an unexpected surface feature.

Beyond passive compliance, active control strategies inspired by biological systems are being developed to optimize the inspection process. One significant challenge is the trade-off between inspection speed and data quality. A robot moving too quickly may skip over subtle defects, while one moving too slowly is inefficient. Research is exploring bio-inspired algorithms, such as those based on the visual saccades of primates or the active sensing whiskers of rodents, to create an "inspection-aware" robotic system [71]. In this paradigm, the robot would first perform a rapid, coarse scan of a large area. Using real-time data processing, it could identify regions of interest (e.g., an anomaly in a thermal image or an acoustic impedance change) and then automatically trigger a fine-scale, high-resolution inspection of that specific area, slowing down and potentially altering the sensor orientation to maximize information gain. This saccadic inspection strategy mimics how animals efficiently gather information from their environment, focusing computational and temporal resources where they are most needed, thereby optimizing the entire inspection workflow for both speed and thoroughness [72].

Specific NDT modalities are being successfully integrated with these novel robotic platforms. Ultrasonic testing (UT), particularly in the phased-array (PAUT) format, is a primary focus due to its ability to provide detailed volumetric images of internal structures. The key requirement is a consistent couplant, typically a water column between the transducer and the surface. Soft robots can integrate water-filled chambers or compliant water-delivery systems directly into their end-effectors, ensuring a stable coupling medium even on vertical surfaces [73]. Recent work by Smith et al. [74] demonstrated a soft, crawling robot that used a conformable bladder filled with circulating water as both an adhesion mechanism (via slight negative pressure) and an ultrasonic couplant, enabling continuous PAUT scanning on a vertical composite panel representative of a turbine blade. Thermographic testing also benefits from robotic deployment. A robotic manipulator can precisely position a heat source (e.g., halogen lamps or flash lamps) and an infrared camera at a fixed distance and angle from the surface, a critical factor for quantitative thermal analysis. The robot's repeatability allows for the collection of pristine, comparable datasets over time, facilitating long-term structural health monitoring [75].

Furthermore, the paradigm of contact-based inspection is evolving from a single-robot, single-sensor task to a collaborative, multi-sensor fusion effort. Inspired by the diverse sensory modalities of biological organisms, researchers are developing heterogeneous robotic teams where different platforms carry complementary NDT payloads. A compelling scenario involves a magnetic climbing robot performing a detailed UT scan of a turbine tower's welds, while a smaller, gecko-inspired crawler deployed by a UAV conducts a localized thermographic inspection of a suspect area on a blade. The data from these different modalities can be fused to provide a more confident and comprehensive diagnosis of a defect than any single method could achieve alone [76]. The control of such systems often leverages swarm intelligence principles, where task allocation and path planning are decentralized, ensuring robust and efficient coverage of the massive turbine structure [77].

The integration of advanced NDT with soft, compliant robotic manipulators is transforming the capabilities of autonomous wind turbine inspection. By moving away from rigid, industrial automation paradigms and embracing bio-inspired principles of compliance, embodied intelligence, and adaptive sensing, these systems are overcoming the critical challenge of delicate, consistent physical contact. This enables the reliable detection of subsurface flaws that are invisible to aerial cameras, providing the essential data needed to move from mere inspection to targeted, in situ robotic repair. The ongoing research in multi-modal sensor fusion and adaptive control algorithms promises to further enhance the speed, accuracy, and autonomy of this vital process, solidifying its role in reducing operational costs and extending the lifespan of wind energy assets.

5.2. Soft robotic systems for in situ repair

The application of soft robotics for in situ repair, while promising, faces significant challenges that must be addressed for industrial adoption. The inherent compliance and softness that enable safe interaction and conformability also result in limitations in force exertion, precision, and speed compared to rigid systems. Furthermore, the durability of soft materials (e.g., silicones, elastomers) under prolonged exposure to UV radiation, temperature cycles, and abrasive dust in field conditions is a major concern [78]. Power and weight requirements for pneumatic or hydraulic actuation can also be prohibitive for mobile platforms. With these challenges in mind, the following section explores the potential applications and ongoing research.

The philosophy of soft robotics for repair is fundamentally bio-inspired, drawing from nature's masters of manipulation and healing. An octopus, for instance, can use its soft, hyper-redundant arms to manipulate objects of virtually any shape with exquisite force control, all while maintaining a secure grip in a turbulent aquatic environment. Similarly, the proboscis of a butterfly or the foot of a gecko can achieve robust yet non-damaging contact with fragile surfaces.

Translating these principles into engineering, soft robotic repair systems are typically composed of compliant actuators made from elastomers like silicone, which are pneumatically, hydraulically, or tendon-driven. This construction allows them to exert forces evenly across a large and irregular area, potentially suiting tasks such as applying and holding a composite patch against a curved blade surface until the adhesive cures. Unlike a rigid arm that would need complex, multi-axis force feedback to achieve uniform pressure, a soft end-effector can passively conform, which may help ensure the entire patch is in intimate contact with the substrate, a critical factor for achieving a strong structural bond [32]. This embodied intelligence could simplify control and increase reliability. For example, a soft robotic hold-down device could be inflated to gently press a pre-impregnated composite patch onto a damaged area, with its internal pressure being the single control variable to ensure consistent application force, potentially compensating for minor surface imperfections or the robot's own slight movements in the wind (see Fig. 6).

Beyond holding and pressing, the actual process of material deposition for filling cracks or leading-edge erosion requires a level of dexterity that remains challenging for current soft robotic systems. Multi-chambered soft robotic grippers are being investigated to hold and maneuver a variety of tools, from dispensing nozzles for injecting resin into subsurface delaminations to sanding heads for surface preparation. The compliance of the gripper may help maintain optimal contact with the surface without requiring millimeter-precise positioning, though this can come at the cost of reduced precision. Research is exploring the use of jamming-based granular grippers, which can transition from a soft, fluid state to a rigid one upon vacuum application, allowing them to mold themselves around a specific tool, grip it firmly, and then release it to pick up another, potentially creating a multi-functional end-effector for a sequence of repair tasks [46]. This tool-changing capability would be essential for complex repair protocols that might involve cleaning, sanding, solvent wiping, filler application, and patch placement in a specific sequence. Furthermore, the development of soft, continuous "trunk" or "tentacle" robots offers a potential paradigm for reaching deep into complex structures, such as the interior of a blade through a small access hole, to perform repairs on internal spar caps or shear webs that are currently inaccessible without major disassembly [47], though control of such hyper-redundant systems remains a significant research challenge.

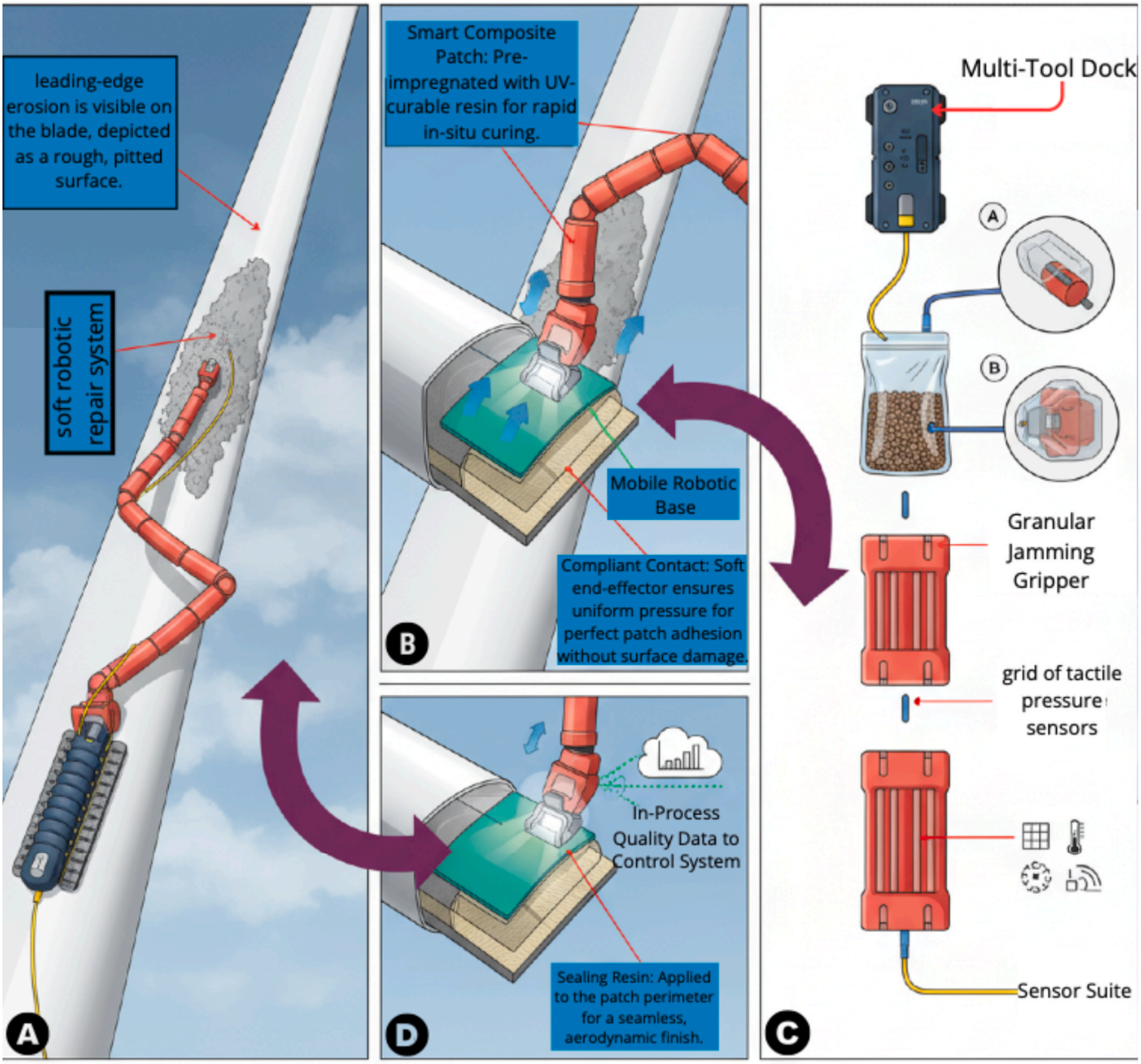


Fig. 6. Conceptual diagram of an autonomous in situ repair system for wind turbine leading-edge erosion using a soft robotic manipulator.

The repair materials themselves are also evolving in synergy with soft robotics, giving rise to the field of "4D printing" or adaptive materials. Research is investigating soft robotic systems deploying smart materials that can change their properties or shape in response to an environmental trigger, such as heat, light, or moisture. For instance, a soft robot could potentially deposit a resin filled with microcapsules containing a healing agent (a concept inspired by biological self-healing processes) or a shape-memory polymer that contracts upon UV exposure, pulling a crack closed [79,80]. However, microcapsule-based self-healing faces fundamental scalability and economic barriers that constrain practical deployment. Manufacturing costs for microcapsule-embedded composites run 3-5 times higher than conventional materials due to specialized processing requirements. More critically, healing capacity is finite. Each microcapsule can rupture only once, providing 2-3 healing cycles maximum before the material requires complete replacement. This negates the 'perpetual self-healing' vision often presented. Additionally, healing efficiency decreases dramatically for damage exceeding 2-3 mm width. Capsule density proves insufficient to bridge larger voids. Field validation under offshore thermal cycling (−20°C to +60°C) and UV exposure shows healing efficacy degradation of 40-60% within 2-3 years. The realistic application may be extending inspection intervals from 6 months to 12 months rather than eliminating manual repair entirely.

The robot could then activate a portable UV source to "trigger" the repair. Another promising avenue is the in situ deposition of thermoplastic composites using a combined soft robotic manipulator and extrusion head. The robot would lay down molten thermoplastic material in a precise pattern to build up a damaged area. The advantage of thermoplastics is that they can be re-melted and re-welded, a feature that soft robots could potentially exploit for future repair cycles or for error correction during the initial repair process [44]. This vision of a closed-loop process, where a robot inspects, decides on a repair strategy, and then executes it with smart materials, represents a long-term goal for autonomous resilience but remains at low Technology Readiness

Levels (TRL 2-4).

The path towards fully autonomous repair is being explored through several pioneering research demonstrations and early-stage commercial systems. The MIRACLE project, a collaborative European effort, has developed a robotic platform that combines magnetic adhesion for mobility with a multi-functional end-effector for blade repair, demonstrating processes like grinding and filler deposition on a test tower [38]. In the academic sphere, researchers at the Wyss Institute have developed soft robotic grippers capable of performing delicate surgical suturing, a manipulation task with a dexterity requirement that could be analogous to the precise placement of a composite patch or the injection of resin into a fine crack [81].

These research systems are beginning to incorporate in-process monitoring, using integrated sensors like cameras or laser profilers to scan the repair area after each step (e.g., after sanding) to ensure quality before proceeding to the next stage. This creates a feedback loop that would be critical for future autonomy, allowing the system to verify its own work and compensate for any deviations.

Table 4 summarizes the state-of-the-art robotic repair techniques for wind turbine blades.

The challenges facing soft robotic repair systems are substantial. As noted earlier, the Technology Readiness Level (TRL) for most systems is still in the 4-6 range, confined to laboratory demonstrations or controlled field trials. Beyond the material durability and power constraints, the development of reliable, robust perception and control algorithms that can manage the often non-linear dynamics of soft actuators in unpredictable real-world conditions is an ongoing area of intense research [78]. Finally, the certification of autonomously executed repairs by aviation and energy authorities presents a significant non-technical barrier; proving that a robotic repair is as reliable as one performed by a certified technician will require extensive validation and a shift in regulatory mindset.

Soft robotic systems are poised to revolutionize the in situ repair of wind turbines by providing the necessary combination of delicate force control, adaptive conformity, and versatile manipulation. By drawing inspiration from biological systems and leveraging advancements in compliant materials and smart material deposition, these robots are transitioning the O&M paradigm from one of costly human intervention to one of continuous, autonomous asset preservation. However, the vision of fully autonomous repair remains idealized. Human intervention will unquestionably remain necessary for the foreseeable future, particularly for major structural load-bearing repairs, complex material supply decisions, evaluating uncertain diagnostic data, and executing robot failure recovery (e.g., retrieving a stranded crawler). While challenges in durability, power, and certification remain, the realistic trajectory is clear: the future of wind energy maintenance lies in a collaborative paradigm where resilient, ever-vigilant robotic systems handle routine interventions and continuous monitoring, thereby reserving human expertise and rope access strictly for high-level decision-making and critical structural interventions.

However, compliance comes with fundamental trade-offs that limit practical deployment. Soft grippers can safely conform to blade curvature without causing surface damage. Yet achieving sufficient force for structural repair bonding remains problematic. Structural composite patch repairs require sustained bonding pressures exceeding 50 kPa to ensure proper adhesive cure and void elimination. Current soft pneumatic actuators generate 10-30 kPa maximum. This proves adequate for gentle handling but insufficient for structural repair. Consequently, soft gripper applications may be limited to cosmetic leading-edge repairs and surface cleaning rather than the load-bearing structural fixes often portrayed in conceptual demonstrations.

Despite impressive laboratory demonstrations of soft manipulator dexterity, field deployment faces a critical speed limitation that undermines economic viability. Soft actuators exhibit slow response due to pneumatic and hydraulic transmission delays and material viscoelasticity. Typical motion speeds reach only 5-10 cm/s compared to 50+ cm/s for conventional rigid manipulators. For large-scale foundation inspection where operational time directly translates to vessel day rates of $50,000-100,000, this speed penalty proves economically prohibitive. A single soft manipulator might require 4-6 h to inspect a monopile circumference versus 1-2 h for a traditional ROV arm. At current performance levels, soft underwater manipulators may only achieve cost-effectiveness for delicate biological sampling tasks where speed remains secondary to gentle handling, not for industrial infrastructure inspection where throughput proves paramount.

5.2.1. *Fundamental constraints and reality check*

Soft robotics faces fundamental limitations that may prove insurmountable for certain wind turbine applications:

The Soft-Rigid Dexterity Gap: Current soft grippers exhibit 1-2 degrees of freedom in practical field deployment versus 6+ DOF for industrial rigid manipulators. This fundamental limitation constrains task repertoire to simple pick-and-place or pressing operations. Complex tool manipulation required for bolt tightening, connector assembly, or

Table 4
State-of-the-art in robotic repair techniques for wind turbine blades.

Repair Technique	Description	Robotic Platform Used	Key Advantages	Key Challenges	TRL
Leading Edge Tape/ Coating Application [36,37]	Automated application of protective polyurethane tapes or erosion-resistant coatings to the leading edge.	UAVs with specialized dispensing systems; crawling robots with roller mechanisms.	Rapid application; prevents further erosion; non-structural repair.	Achieving uniform thickness; adhesion quality in field conditions; surface preparation.	6-7
Automatic Composite Patching [38,39]	Application of pre-cured or pre-preg composite patches using compliant mechanisms and in situ curing.	Magnetic climbing robots; gecko-inspired crawlers with soft end-effectors.	Restores structural integrity; automated precision; Consistent bond quality.	Complex path planning on curved surfaces, achieving vacuum bag equivalence; Curing cycle control.	5-6
In situ Resin Injection [40,41]	Precision delivery of two-part epoxy resins into delaminations and cracks using needle injectors.	Snake robots for internal access; crawling robots with syringe pumps and vision systems.	Repairs subsurface damage; minimal surface disruption; targeted application.	Ensuring complete void filling, resin viscosity control; Needle clogging.	5
Robotic Grinding & Surface Preparation [42,43]	Automated removal of damaged material and surface profiling using rotary tools.	Rigid robotic arms on mobile bases; hybrid soft-rigid systems with force control.	Excellent surface preparation quality; removes stress concentrations; Repeatable process.	Dust management, Controlling depth of cut; Vibration-induced accuracy loss.	7
Additive Repair (Thermoplastic Deposition) [44,45]	Layer-by-layer material deposition using fused filament fabrication (FFF) or directed energy deposition.	Gantry systems; 6-axis robotic arms with extrusion heads.	Complex geometry repair, Material versatility; Potential for functional grading.	Limited mechanical properties, Interlayer adhesion; slow deposition rates.	4-5
UV-Activated Patch Repair [46,47]	Application of patches with embedded photo-initiators, cured by integrated UV sources.	Soft robotic manipulators with integrated UV lamps.	Rapid curing (<5 min); energy efficient; Low thermal stress on substrate.	Limited to surface repairs, UV penetration depth, and sensitivity to shadowed areas.	5

precision cutting remains beyond reach. No plausible near-term research pathway exists to bridge this gap while maintaining the compliance advantage. Increasing soft actuator DOF proportionally increases control complexity and reduces force output.

Material Durability Under Prolonged Offshore Exposure: Silicone and elastomer materials degrade under continuous UV exposure. Tensile strength reductions of 30-50% occur after 12-18 months in offshore conditions. Combined with salt-induced stress cracking and biofouling accumulation in underwater applications, soft robot operational lifespan may be limited to 2-3 years versus 10-15 years for rigid systems. The frequent replacement requirement undermines total cost of ownership advantages, particularly for permanently deployed systems.

Force-Compliance Trade-off Cannot Be Eliminated: The fundamental material property that enables safe soft robot interaction, high compliance, inherently limits force exertion. Attempts to increase output force through thicker walls or higher pressure reduce compliance and negate the safety advantage. This creates an insurmountable barrier for tasks requiring both delicate interaction AND high force, such as structural repair where gentle surface contact must be followed by 50+ kPa bonding pressure.

Realistic Application Scope: Given these constraints, soft robotics will find niche rather than wholesale applications in wind O&M. A clear task suitability summary for soft robots (see Table 5) includes:

Highly Suitable: Gentle sensor placement on operating turbines (vibration-sensitive equipment), localized surface cleaning, and inspection tasks requiring conformable contact (e.g., curved surface ultrasound).

Conditionally Suitable: Human-collaborative tools for technician assistance, and cosmetic leading-edge tape or fluid application where precise force exertion is not critical.

Unsuitable/Economically Impractical: Major structural load-bearing repairs, high-torque operations (e.g., bolt tightening), and precision grinding or cutting. These tasks require rigid mechanics to exert forces exceeding 50+ kPa, which soft actuators cannot reliably achieve.

The vision of fully soft robotic repair systems completely replacing human technicians appears economically and technically implausible within the 10-year horizon. A more realistic paradigm uses selective soft componentry integrated into hybrid rigid-soft systems, leaving heavy structural interventions to conventional rigid manipulators or human experts.

6. Synthesis, challenges, and future outlook

6.1. Interdisciplinary synthesis: bridging robotics, biology, and wind energy engineering

Beyond the technological innovations, the economic viability of bio-inspired robotic systems must be critically evaluated. While the initial research and development costs for these advanced systems are substantial, their potential for reducing the Levelized Cost of Energy (LCOE) is significant. Operations and Maintenance (O&M) accounts for 25-35% of offshore wind LCOE, with single-day downtime for modern turbines costing upwards of $50,000 in lost revenue [4]. A robotic inspection system costing $100,000 would pay for itself after preventing just two downtime events, not accounting for the additional safety benefits and reduced vessel requirements.

Furthermore, studies indicate that autonomous robotic systems could reduce annual O&M costs by 20-30% through increased inspection frequency, early fault detection, and reduced human risk exposure [49,82]. The transition from reactive to predictive maintenance enabled by persistent robotic monitoring represents a paradigm shift in wind farm economics, potentially extending turbine lifespan by 3-5 years through timely interventions. However, this economic promise must be balanced against the current high development costs and unproven long-term reliability of many bio-inspired systems in harsh offshore environments.

The preceding analysis demonstrates that the path toward fully autonomous and resilient wind energy operations is not a linear progression within a single discipline but rather the outcome of a deep and purposeful convergence of robotics, biology, and wind energy engineering. This interdisciplinary triad forms a virtuous cycle of innovation: biological systems provide a proven repository of design principles for efficiency, resilience, and adaptation; robotics serves as the translational medium to embody these principles into functional machines; and wind energy engineering defines the critical real-world challenges and performance metrics that focus and validate these bio-inspired solutions. The synthesis presented in this review reveals that this convergence is not merely additive but multiplicative, creating capabilities that are unattainable through siloed approaches. The transformative potential of this fusion lies in its holistic addressal of the wind energy lifecycle, from the fundamental design of turbines to their daily inspection and long-term maintenance, ultimately targeting the significant reduction of the Levelized Cost of Energy (LCOE).

The first and most evident bridge is in the domain of mobility and access. The harsh, complex, and vast environment of a wind farm encompassing soaring blades, vertical towers, and submerged foundations presents a mobility challenge that conventional engineering struggles to solve efficiently. Biology, through millions of years of evolutionary pressure, offers a catalog of refined locomotion strategies. As detailed in Sections 3.1 and 3.2, the application of avian flight dynamics has led to morphing-wing UAVs that achieve unprecedented stability in the turbulent wake of turbines, a direct translation of biological principle to engineered robustness [6,19]. Similarly, the adhesion mechanisms of geckos and the peristaltic gait of inchworms have been abstracted into climbing robots that can traverse the delicate composite skin of blades and the ferromagnetic surface of towers with minimal energy expenditure and risk of damage [30,48]. This bio-inspired approach to mobility directly confronts the high costs and dangers of human access, enabling a new paradigm of frequent, low-cost physical presence. The recent work by Tovarnov and Bykov [30] on hybrid locomotion robots capable of autonomous transitions between turbine components exemplifies how this synthesis is evolving beyond mimicking a single organism to creating hybrid systems that combine multiple biological strategies for comprehensive coverage.

The second critical bridge concerns autonomy and perception in unstructured environments. The GPS-denied, perceptually degraded, and dynamically complex airspace around a wind turbine is a domain where traditional robotic navigation systems, reliant on pre-programmed paths and external beacons, are fundamentally inadequate. Here, the synthesis with biology moves from mechanics to

Table 5
Soft Robotics vs Conventional Methods for Blade Maintenance.

Task	Soft Approach	Cost	Time	TRL	Conventional Method	Cost	Time	TRL	Superior Approach
Surface cleaning	Compliant brush	$15K	4 h	4	Water jet + crawler	$2K	2 h	9	**Conventional**
Visual inspection	Soft-tethered camera	$8K	3 h	5	UAV with camera	$5K	1 h	7	**Conventional**
Leading-edge cosmetic repair	Soft applicator	$12K	2 h	5	Manual tape application	$3K	1.5 h	9	**Conventional (currently)**
Contact ultrasound NDT	Compliant probe holder	$20K	2.5 h	4	Rigid arm with force control	$35K	2 h	6	**Soft** (when mature)
Internal cavity inspection	Soft continuum arm	$40K	5 h	3	Borescope rigid probe	$8K	3 h	8	**Conventional**
Structural patch bonding	Soft pressing system	$50K	6 h	3	Vacuum bag + manual	$5K	4 h	9	**Conventional**
Delicate sensor placement	Soft gripper	$10K	1 h	5	Human technician	$2K + risk	2 h	9	**Soft** (safety advantage)

computation, drawing inspiration from the neural and behavioral strategies of animals. As explored in Section 4, the optical flow processing of insects provides a model for lightweight, robust velocity and obstacle avoidance systems for UAVs [59], while the echolocation of bats informs active sensing and mapping strategies in visually obscured conditions [60]. Furthermore, the collective intelligence of social insects and flocking birds has been formalized into powerful decentralized algorithms like Ant Colony Optimization (ACO) and Particle Swarm Optimization (PSO) for multi-robot task allocation and path planning [62,63]. This bio-inspired autonomy is not just about replacing a human operator; it is about creating a system that is inherently resilient, adaptive, and scalable. The emergent behavior of a UAV swarm inspecting a wind farm, where failure of a single agent does not compromise the mission, is a direct import of swarm-level resilience observed in nature [23,77]. This shift from fragile, centralized control to robust, decentralized intelligence is perhaps the most profound contribution of biology to the long-term vision of the "self-operating" wind farm.

A third, and increasingly crucial, interdisciplinary bridge is being formed in the realm of contact-based intervention and repair. While aerial drones excel at visual inspection, many critical defects require physical contact for detection and remediation. Traditional rigid robots are ill-suited for this delicate interaction, risking damage to the turbine. The synthesis with soft robotics, a field itself deeply rooted in biological inspiration, provides the solution. The compliant, deformable structures of octopus arms and plant tendrils have inspired soft manipulators that can conform to complex blade curvatures, ensuring consistent contact for Non-Destructive Testing (NDT) and applying uniform pressure for patch repairs [44,43]. This "embodied intelligence" allows the hardware itself to solve problems of alignment and force control that would require complex software and sensors in a rigid system. The recent advancements in granular jamming grippers [45] and multi-material 3D printing for soft actuators are further closing the gap between biological capability and robotic implementation, enabling a single system to perform a sequence of repair tasks from gripping a tool to applying a patch with gentle, adaptive force. This fusion of soft robotics and biomimetics is transforming the vision of in situ repair from a remote possibility to a tangible, albeit still developing, reality [78,81].

Finally, this interdisciplinary dialogue is transcending operations and maintenance to directly influence the fundamental design of wind turbines themselves. Biomimicry is no longer just for the robots that service the turbines but also for the turbines' own morphology and material composition. As discussed in Section 6, the tubercle-lined flippers of humpback whales have inspired leading-edge blade modifications that delay stall and increase aerodynamic efficiency [83,84], while the silent flight of owls has led to serrated trailing edges that significantly reduce acoustic emissions [85]. Beyond aerodynamics, the biological concept of self-healing, seen in everything from human skin to plant vasculature, is being engineered into composite materials through microcapsule and vascular systems [79,86]. The integration of shape-memory polymers [80,87] can create blades that not only heal cracks but also passively alleviate loads through bend-twist coupling, a feature inspired by the wings of large birds [88]. This represents the ultimate synthesis: creating wind energy infrastructure that is not inert, but active and resilient, blurring the line between the biological model and the engineered artifact. To realize this, structural and operational co-design is required. For example, embedding ferromagnetic tracks or standardized docking interfaces within composite blades directly facilitates crawler adhesion and wireless charging without compromising aerodynamic efficiency. Similarly, co-designing the internal shear webs of blades with bio-inspired, obstacle-free 'arterial' pathways allows miniature snake robots to navigate seamlessly for internal inspections. This integrated bio-inspired design philosophy, moving from component-level optimization to system-level resilience, promises next-generation turbines that are not only more efficient but also inherently cheaper to maintain.

The interdisciplinary synthesis of biology, robotics, and wind energy engineering is far more than a novel academic pursuit; it is a necessary and powerful framework for solving the most intractable challenges facing the wind industry. By learning from nature's time-tested strategies for movement, perception, cooperation, and healing, we are equipping ourselves with a new toolkit for innovation. This review has charted the progress across this interdisciplinary landscape, showing how bio-inspired robots are already enhancing inspection and repair and how biomimetic principles are beginning to redefine the turbines themselves. However, it is critical to acknowledge the fundamental limitations of bio-engineering mapping. Biological organisms benefit from continuous cellular regeneration, metabolic energy extraction from their environment, and millions of years of evolutionary trial-and-error, traits that engineered systems cannot simply replicate. Translating biological inspiration into hardware often reveals severe manufacturing constraints, inferior energy densities compared to biological metabolisms, and a stark lack of environmental robustness in synthetic soft materials. Therefore, the continued and deepened collaboration between biologists, roboticists, and wind engineers is not merely beneficial but essential to pragmatically balance biomimetic ideals with strict industrial realities. It is the key to unlocking a future of wind energy that is not only clean and abundant but also truly autonomous, resilient, and cost-effective, securing its pivotal role in a sustainable global energy system.

6.2. *Critical analysis of challenges and barriers*

Despite the significant promise of bio-inspired and soft robotics, their pathway to widespread adoption in the wind energy sector is fraught with multifaceted challenges. Acknowledging and systematically addressing these barriers is crucial for guiding research, development, and policy. The following critical analysis synthesizes the primary hurdles across technical, economic, regulatory, and environmental domains, as summarized in Table 6 below.

The matrix reveals that the challenges are deeply interconnected. For instance, the technical hurdle of low TRL directly inflates the economic barrier of high initial cost, while the regulatory vacuum surrounding autonomous repairs stifles the business case that would otherwise justify further technical investment. Technically, while individual components show great promise, the integration into a reliable, persistent, and fully autonomous system remains the paramount challenge. The gap between a laboratory demonstration and a system that can operate for months on an offshore turbine with minimal human intervention is substantial. It is equally important to learn from technological pathways that were not adopted or failed in field conditions. For instance, early attempts to deploy highly articulated, purely flapping-wing (ornithopter) drones for offshore inspections were largely abandoned; while aerodynamically efficient in theory, their complex mechanical linkages suffered rapid fatigue failure in turbulent, salt-laden winds, proving economically unviable compared to hybrid tilt-rotor designs. Similarly, purely vacuum-based climbing robots have frequently failed in field trials due to their inability to maintain a reliable seal over heavily bio-fouled or eroded blade surfaces. Power autonomy remains another critical bottleneck; a morphing-wing UAV or a magnetic crawler is of limited value if it can only operate for 30-60 min before requiring manual retrieval and recharging [90]. Furthermore, the harsh offshore environment poses a severe test for material durability, where salt spray, humidity, and UV radiation can quickly degrade the sensitive adhesives and soft actuators that are central to these bio-inspired approaches [91].

From an economic perspective, the high upfront cost of development and the unproven TCO create a "valley of death" between research prototypes and commercial products. Wind farm operators, under significant financial pressure, are inherently risk-averse and require compelling evidence of reliability and cost savings before replacing established, if expensive, methods like rope-access technicians and service operation vessels (SOVs). The recent analysis by McMorland et al. [93] underscores that operational data for robotic systems remains too

Table 6
Challenge matrix for the adoption of bio-inspired and soft robotics in wind energy.

Domain	Challenge Description	Potential Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Technical	Low Technology Readiness Level (TRL): Many systems, especially soft robotic manipulators and multimodal platforms, are at TRL 4-5 (lab/bench validation) [89]	Delayed deployment; inability to meet the reliability demands of industrial O&M.	Increased funding for field prototyping and long-duration testing in real-world environments; development of standardized testing protocols.
	Power Autonomy and Endurance: High energy consumption for computation, adhesion (electromagnets), and actuation (pneumatics) limits mission duration [90].	Reduced inspection/repair coverage per deployment necessitates frequent, costly recovery/ recharging.	Integration of lightweight energy harvesting (solar, wind); development of high-energy-density batteries; deployment of inductive charging stations on turbines.
	Robustness and Durability in Harsh Conditions: Soft materials degrade under UV exposure, temperature cycles, and abrasive dust; complex mechanisms foul with salt and ice [91].	Short operational lifespan, high failure rates; increased maintenance for the robots themselves.	Development of novel, weather-resistant materials (e.g., UV-stable elastomers, anti-fouling coatings); design for resilience and easy field repair.
	Perception and Autonomy in Dynamic Environments: Reliable navigation and decision-making in perceptually degraded conditions (rain, spray, darkness) remain unsolved [92].	Collisions, incomplete or failed missions; inability to operate in all required weather windows.	Fusion of multi-modal sensors (thermal, mm-wave radar); advancement of robust, explainable AI and simulation-to-real (Sim2Real) transfer learning.
	Standardization and Integration: Lack of common interfaces and communication protocols hinders the creation of heterogeneous robotic teams (aerial, climbing, underwater) [17].	Vendor lock-in, inefficient operations; inability to mix-and-match best-in-class robotic platforms.	Industry-wide consortiums to define open standards for robotic docking, data sharing, and command-and-control.
Economic	High Initial R&D and Unit Cost: Bio-inspired designs often require complex, non-standard components and manufacturing processes (e.g., 3D-printed soft actuators).	Prohibitive capital expenditure; long return-on-investment (ROI) period compared to conventional methods.	Public-private partnerships to share R&D risk; design for manufacturability and scalability; demonstrating clear TCO reduction via increased asset uptime.
	Unproven Business Case and Total Cost of Ownership (TCO): Limited long-term operational data makes it difficult to prove superior TCO over traditional vessel/diver-based O&M [93].	Investor and operator hesitancy; preference for known, albeit expensive, conventional methods.	Creation of detailed digital twins and cost-benefit models; pilot projects with rigorous, transparent cost and performance monitoring.
	High Cost of Certification and Verification: Proving the safety and reliability of autonomous systems for aviation and marine authorities is a complex, lengthy, and expensive process.	Slows down market entry; adds significant overhead to development costs.	Early and continuous engagement with regulators (e.g., EASA, DNV); development of novel certification frameworks for adaptive and learning systems.
Regulatory	Liability and Safety Frameworks: Unclear liability in case of a robot-caused incident (e.g., blade damage, collision with manned aircraft or vessels) [94].	Legal and insurance uncertainties that deter operators from adopting autonomous systems.	Establishment of clear codes of practice, insurance products, and regulatory sandboxes for testing autonomous systems in controlled areas.
	Air and Maritime Traffic Management: Integration of UAVs and unmanned surface vessels (USVs) into busy airspace and sea lanes without disrupting other users.	Restricted operational zones; complex approval processes for each mission.	Development of UTM (Unmanned Traffic Management) and maritime equivalents: geofencing and reliable detect-and-avoid technologies.
	Certification of Autonomous Repairs: Regulatory bodies lack frameworks for approving structural repairs performed autonomously by robots, which are inherently variable.	Prevents the implementation of the most valuable application in situ repair locking in human-dependent processes.	Research into in-process quality assurance and non-destructive evaluation to validate robotic repairs to a certifiable standard.
Environmental	Ecological Impact: Potential for collisions with birds and bats; underwater noise from robotic systems disturbing marine life [65].	Harm to local wildlife; project delays due to non-compliance with environmental regulations.	Conducting thorough environmental impact assessments, scheduling operations to avoid key migration/ nesting periods and developing quieter propulsion.
	Lifecycle and Waste Management: End-of-life disposal of complex robots, especially those with specialized composites, batteries, and soft materials.	Contradiction with the sustainability goals of renewable energy; creation of a new waste stream.	Designing robots for disassembly, reuse, and recycling; establishing take-back programs; using biodegradable materials where possible.
	Resource Footprint: The	Offsets some of the carbon	Lifecycle analysis (LCA) to guide eco-

(*continued on next page*)

Table 6 (*continued*)

Domain	Challenge Description	Potential Impact	Mitigation Strategy
	environmental cost of manufacturing and transporting advanced robotic systems.	savings achieved by wind energy.	design; use of sustainable materials; optimizing logistics for robotic deployment.

sparse to build robust financial models, making it difficult to secure investment. The regulatory landscape presents a different but equally formidable set of barriers, as the current frameworks for aviation and maritime operations are built around human operators.Certifying a non-deterministic, learning-based autonomous system for operation near critical infrastructure is a novel challenge for agencies like the European Union Aviation Safety Agency (EASA) [94]. Questions of liability in the event of an accident are largely unanswered, creating significant hesitation among operators and insurers.

Finally, the environmental challenges remind us that the sustainability of the solution itself must be scrutinized. The very purpose of wind energy is to reduce environmental impact, and it is therefore imperative that the robotic fleets deployed to maintain it do not inadvertently harm local ecosystems through collisions or pollution. Proactive environmental monitoring and the development of "eco-friendly" robotic designs will be essential for obtaining a social and regulatory license to operate [65]. Overcoming these barriers requires a coordinated, multi-stakeholder effort. Researchers must focus on robustness, integration, and real-world validation. Industry must engage in pilot projects and standard-setting. Governments and regulators must create adaptive frameworks that encourage innovation while ensuring safety. Only through such a concerted approach can the immense transformative potential of bio-inspired and soft robotics be fully realized for the wind energy sector.

Industrial and Ecosystem Fragmentation: Beyond technical and economic hurdles, the fragmented nature of the wind energy industry presents a significant adoption barrier. The separation of responsibilities between turbine manufacturers, wind farm developers, and independent O&M service providers can create misaligned incentives and hinder the integrated system-level co-design necessary for seamless robotic integration. Overcoming this fragmentation will require new business models and collaborative frameworks that demonstrate clear value to all stakeholders throughout the project lifecycle.

6.2.1. *Power autonomy and energy harvesting*

The mission endurance of bio-inspired robotic systems is critically constrained by power autonomy, forming a fundamental bottleneck for widespread adoption. While these robots often exhibit superior energy efficiency in locomotion, such as the gliding flight of morphing-wing UAVs or the undulating propulsion of fish-like underwater vehicles their operational duration remains limited by the energy density of current battery technologies. This is exacerbated by the high power demands of on board computation for autonomous navigation, sensor suites for inspection, and, in the case of soft robots, pneumatic or hydraulic pumps for actuation. For offshore wind farms, where deployment logistics are complex and weather windows are limited, a robot that can only operate for one to 2 h per charge offers a marginal improvement over conventional methods. The challenge is not merely to reduce power consumption but to create systems capable of persistent or near-persistent operation. The solution lies in the development of integrated energy harvesting systems that allow robots to recharge from their ambient environment. Inspired by the foraging behavior of animals, research is advancing towards multi-modal energy scavenging. For aerial platforms, this includes integrating flexible solar cells onto the surfaces of wings and fuselages to extend flight time during daylight operations [95]. For climbing robots, a promising avenue is the use of piezoelectric or electromagnetic generators that can convert the vibrational energy of the turbine tower into useable electrical power [96]. Perhaps the most transformative concept is the deployment of wireless inductive charging pads at strategic locations on the turbine, such as the nacelle or base of the tower, creating "robot refueling stations" and enabling a paradigm of continuous, cyclical inspection where a robot can work until its battery is low, dock to recharge, and then resume its mission without human intervention [97]. Overcoming the power autonomy hurdle is therefore a multi-faceted endeavor, requiring co-design of low-power mechanics, intelligent power management algorithms, and ambient energy harvesting systems to unlock the full potential of long-duration robotic autonomy.

6.2.2. *Reliability and certification in harsh environments*

The operational environment of a wind turbine is a crucible that tests the limits of robotic reliability. Bio-inspired and soft robots, while offering unparalleled adaptability, often introduce novel failure modes not encountered with traditional rigid systems. The very compliance of soft robotic manipulators makes them susceptible to degradation from ultraviolet radiation, ozone, temperature extremes, and abrasive dust, which can cause material embrittlement, tearing, or changes in actuation characteristics [98]. Adhesion mechanisms are particularly vulnerable; gecko-inspired dry adhesives can be fouled by salt, pollen, or moisture, while magnetic systems can accumulate metallic debris that interferes with locomotion. Furthermore, the complex dynamics of systems like morphing wings or underwater snake robots present significant challenges for control and predictability under turbulent and unpredictable loading conditions. These reliability concerns directly translate into a formidable certification challenge. Aviation and maritime regulatory bodies, such as EASA and the American Bureau of Shipping (ABS), have well-established frameworks for certifying rigid, deterministic systems but lack protocols for adaptive, soft, or learning-based autonomous systems. How does one certify a robot whose control policy evolves through experience or whose soft body deforms unpredictably upon contact? The path forward requires a dual approach. First, on the technical side, it involves developing accelerated lifetime testing protocols specifically for soft and bio-inspired components and creating robust fault-detection and recovery algorithms [99]. Second, on the regulatory front, it necessitates the creation of new certification frameworks based on a "trusted autonomy" paradigm. This could involve certifying the *process* of how a robot is trained and validated such as through millions of hours of simulation testing across a wide range of scenarios rather than certifying its performance for every conceivable real-world edge case. Demonstrating a verifiable "safety envelope" within which the robot can operate reliably is key to gaining the trust of operators and regulators alike [100].

6.2.3. *High initial costs and business model adoption*

The sophisticated research, development, and specialized manufacturing required for bio-inspired robots often result in high initial unit costs, creating a significant barrier to entry. A single advanced morphing-wing UAV or a complex magnetic-climbing robot with soft manipulators can represent a capital expenditure an order of magnitude greater than a conventional industrial drone. For wind farm operators, whose primary focus is on minimizing the Levelized Cost of Energy (LCOE), this high upfront cost presents a substantial financial risk, especially when the long-term reliability and maintenance costs of these novel systems are unproven. This creates a "valley of death" between successful research prototypes and widespread commercial deployment. The core challenges and their interrelationships are summarized in Fig. 7. Overcoming this economic barrier requires more than just technological refinement; it demands a clear demonstration of a superior business case and potentially new operational models.

A critical step is to move beyond comparing unit costs and instead conduct comprehensive Total Cost of Ownership (TCO) analyses that account for the value of reduced downtime, eliminated human risk, and

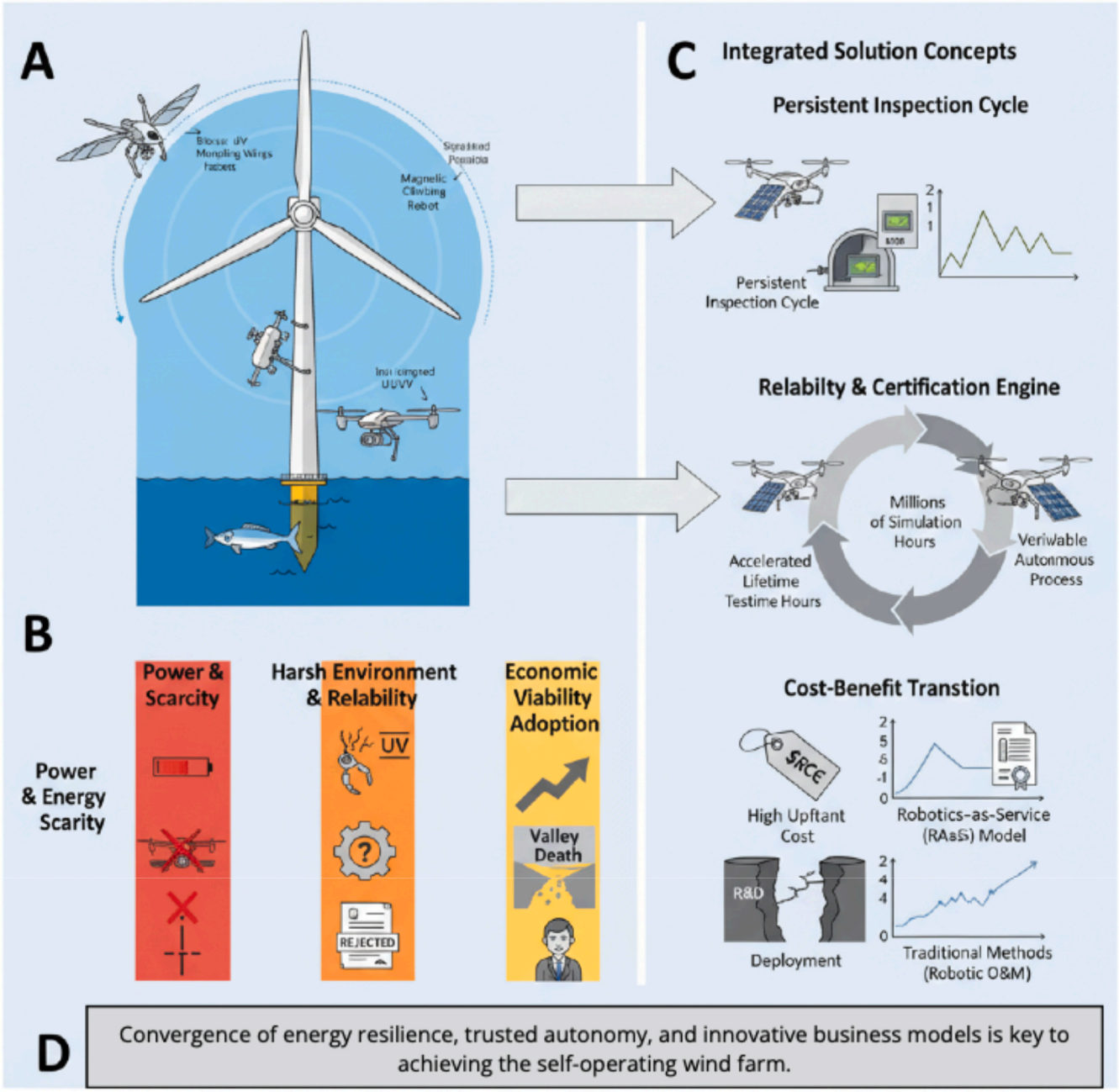


Fig. 7. The triad of core challenges for autonomous robotic operations and maintenance in wind energy.

the prevention of catastrophic failures through more frequent and detailed inspections [101]. For instance, the cost of a single day of downtime for a modern offshore turbine can eclipse the price of an entire robotic inspection system. To de-risk adoption for operators, new business models are emerging. Instead of a capital purchase, Robotics-as-a-Service (RaaS) is becoming a prominent model, where a service provider owns, maintains, and operates the robotic fleet, selling inspection and repair data to the wind farm operator on a subscription or per-mission basis [102]. This transfers the capital and operational risk from the operator to the service provider, who can achieve economies of scale by serving multiple wind farms. Furthermore, public-private partnerships and grant funding for large-scale pilot deployments are essential to generate the robust, long-term operational data needed to prove reliability and build confidence across the industry, ultimately catalyzing market adoption and driving down costs through increased production volumes.

6.3. Roadmap for future research

The successful maturation and integration of bio-inspired and soft robotics into the wind energy sector hinge on a coordinated, phased research and development strategy. This roadmap outlines critical research thrusts across short-term (0-3 years), mid-term (3-10 years), and long-term (10+ years) horizons, aiming to transition these technologies from promising prototypes to indispensable components of a resilient energy infrastructure. The overarching goal is to evolve from isolated robotic tools to a fully integrated, autonomous ecosystem that significantly reduces the Levelized Cost of Energy (LCOE). In the short term (0-3 years), the focus must be on technology consolidation and field validation. The priority is to bridge the gap between laboratory demonstrations and proven field readiness. This involves hardening existing platforms for real-world durability, addressing the fundamental power bottleneck, and developing the foundational software for reliable

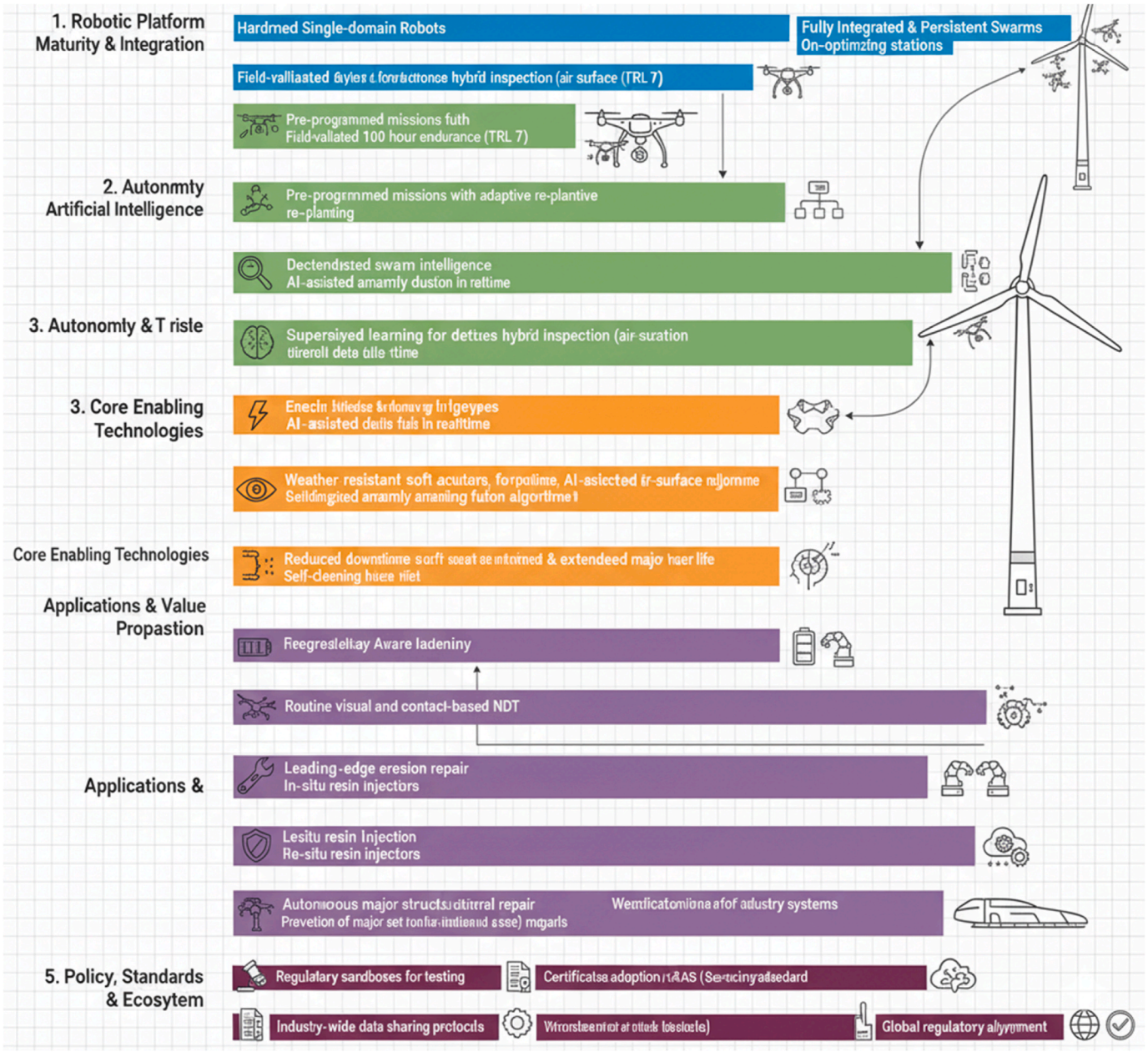


Fig. 8. Technology roadmap for the integration of bio-inspired robotics in wind energy.

autonomy.

Key research initiatives should include the development of advanced composite materials and coatings to protect soft robotic components from UV degradation, saltwater corrosion, and abrasive dust [103]. Concurrently, research must pivot towards integrated energy harvesting, such as optimizing flexible solar cells for UAV surfaces and developing efficient vibrational energy harvesters for climbing platforms, to extend mission times from minutes to hours [104]. In parallel, the creation of open-source simulation environments and high-fidelity digital twins of wind farms is crucial. These platforms will enable the rapid training and testing of swarm coordination algorithms and navigation controllers in millions of simulated, high-risk scenarios before real-world deployment, significantly accelerating the development of robust autonomy [105]. The key deliverable of this phase is the generation of extensive, validated field data from pilot projects, proving the reliability and initial cost-benefit of robotic systems for specific, high-value tasks like blade inspection and scour monitoring.

The mid-term (3-10 years) vision shifts towards system integration and adaptive autonomy. The goal is to move from single-robot, single-task operations to collaborative, heterogeneous teams that can perform complex, multi-step missions. This phase will see the rise of the "heterogeneous robotic team," where a single mission might involve a mothership UAV deploying a micro-crawler for a detailed blade repair, all while an underwater swarm maps the foundation. Research will focus on standardizing communication protocols and docking interfaces to enable this collaboration, allowing different robots to share power, data, and computational resources [106]. A major research thrust will be in "explainable AI" and meta-learning, enabling robots to not only perform tasks but also understand their own limitations, diagnose failures, and adapt their behavior to unforeseen circumstances, such as a novel structural defect or extreme weather event [82]. This is also the phase for pioneering in situ repair. Research should focus on the closed-loop "inspect-plan-repair-verify" cycle, integrating advanced NDT with soft robotic manipulators capable of handling and deploying smart materials like UV-curable composites or self-healing resins [107]. The successful outcome of this phase is the demonstration of a fully autonomous repair

of a minor blade defect, from initial detection to final quality assurance, without human intervention.

Looking into the long term (10+ years), the vision expands to the creation of a cognitive and resilient wind farm ecosystem. Here, the line between the robotic system and the wind turbine infrastructure itself becomes blurred. The research frontier will be the development of "cognitive wind farms," where fleets of diverse robots are permanently embedded within the energy infrastructure. These systems would operate as a unified nervous system, continuously monitoring the health of each turbine and the farm as a whole, making predictive maintenance decisions, and autonomously executing repairs. Key research will involve the development of cross-platform federated learning, where robots share learned knowledge about turbine conditions, leading to a collective intelligence that improves over the entire fleet's lifetime [108]. Furthermore, the synergy between robotic O&M and bio-inspired turbine design will reach its full potential. Robots will not just maintain turbines; they will interact with next-generation turbines featuring biomimetic surfaces optimized for robotic adhesion and integrated docking stations. The ultimate long-term goal is the realization of turbines with intrinsic self-healing capabilities, where robotic systems act as catalysts or triggers for these processes, such as by delivering healing agents to vascular networks within the blade structure or applying a localized heat source to activate shape-memory polymers [109]. This culminates in a transformative paradigm where the wind farm is a self-sustaining, self-repairing entity, with bio-inspired robotics as its essential, autonomous caretaker, ensuring maximum energy output and longevity with minimal human operational input.

6.4. Economic viability and LCOE reduction potential

The economic argument for bio-inspired robotic systems must be substantiated through quantitative analysis. Traditional offshore wind O&M costs range from $120,000 to $150,000 per day when accounting for vessel rental, crew, and lost production [4,49]. In comparison, a robotic inspection system with an estimated capital cost of $50,000-$100,000 could pay for itself after preventing just 1-2 days of downtime. More significantly, studies indicate that autonomous robotic systems could reduce annual O&M costs by 20-30% through increased inspection frequency, early fault detection, and reduced human risk exposure [49,106]. The transition from reactive to predictive maintenance enabled by persistent robotic monitoring represents a paradigm shift in wind farm economics. For a typical 500 MW offshore wind farm with annual O&M costs of $25-35 million, robotic systems could potentially yield savings of $5-10 million annually. Furthermore, the extension of turbine lifespan by 3-5 years through timely interventions represents substantial additional value. It is crucial to emphasize, however, that the realization of these LCOE reductions is highly dependent on specific operational conditions, such as prevailing energy prices, local wind speed constraints, and baseline maintenance frequencies. These projected benefits should not be interpreted as guaranteed savings, but rather as potential gains heavily contingent upon overcoming current development costs and demonstrating sustained robotic reliability in harsh offshore environments.

7. Conclusion

This review has synthesized the current state of bio-inspired and soft robotics, demonstrating their transformative potential for wind energy operations. However, the path to widespread adoption is not solely technological; the fragmented wind farm ecosystem, involving multiple stakeholders, presents challenges for the integrated system-level co-design and cost-sharing necessary for seamless robotic integration. Successful adoption will therefore require not only technological maturity but also new business models and collaboration frameworks that demonstrate clear value to all parties throughout the project lifecycle. Despite these hurdles, the continued convergence of biology and robotics offers a promising toolkit for reducing operational costs and risks, solidifying wind power's role in a sustainable energy future. By systematically examining the convergence of biological principles with robotic engineering, we have illustrated how this interdisciplinary approach directly confronts the most pressing challenges in wind farm operations and maintenance. From the development of agile aerial platforms with morphing wings for stable flight in turbulent wakes to the creation of climbing robots that emulate the adhesive prowess of geckos and the locomotive gaits of inchworms, bio-inspired solutions are fundamentally enhancing our ability to access and interact with wind turbine infrastructure. Furthermore, the integration of soft robotics introduces an unprecedented level of delicate compliance, enabling safe, contact-based non-destructive testing and complex in situ repair procedures on delicate composite surfaces that were previously the exclusive domain of human technicians working in hazardous conditions.

Beyond robotic agents, the influence of biomimicry is profoundly shaping the next generation of wind energy infrastructure itself. Biomimetic blade designs, incorporating features like humpback whale tubercles for improved aerodynamics and owl-inspired serrations for noise reduction, are leading to turbines that are more efficient and socially acceptable. The emerging frontier of intrinsic self-healing materials, inspired by biological wound repair, promises a future where turbine components can autonomously recover from damage, further reducing maintenance needs. However, the widespread adoption of these transformative technologies is not without significant hurdles. Critical challenges remain in achieving sufficient power autonomy and endurance, ensuring the long-term reliability and certification of soft and adaptive systems in harsh environments, and validating a compelling business case to overcome high initial costs. Addressing these barriers requires a concerted, multi-stakeholder effort focused on hardening technologies through real-world validation, developing new regulatory frameworks for autonomous systems, and creating innovative business models like Robotics-as-a-Service.

Looking forward, the trajectory points towards an integrated cognitive ecosystem where heterogeneous teams of aerial, climbing, and underwater robots operate synergistically, not just as external tools, but as a permanent, intelligent nervous system for the wind farm. This vision of a self-sustaining, self-repairing energy infrastructure, where bio-inspired robots continuously monitor, maintain, and even enhance the assets they serve, is the ultimate promise of this field. The continued and deepened collaboration between biologists, roboticists, and wind energy engineers is therefore not merely beneficial but essential. By persistently learning from and emulating nature's time-tested strategies, we can secure the future of wind power, significantly driving down the levelized cost of energy and solidifying its pivotal role in a sustainable and resilient global energy system.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests: Weimin Zhang reports financial support was provided by Zhengzhou Research Institute, Beijing Institute of Technology. Xiaopeng Chen reports financial support was provided by Science and Technology Innovation Program of Beijing Institute of Technology. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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